



HIGHER HEALTH

Higher Education & Training:
Health, Wellness & Development Centre



2023/24

Annual Report



higher education
& training
Department:
Higher Education and Training
REPUBLIC OF SOUTH AFRICA



UNIVERSITIES
SOUTH AFRICA





Published by:

Higher Education and Training Health, Wellness and Development Centre trading
as HIGHER HEALTH

August 2024

Company registration number:

2017/419731/08

Address:

Wild Olive Building,
Riverfalls Office Park,
262 Rose Avenue, Centurion, Pretoria

Tel: 011 030 0113

Contents



A BRIEF INTRODUCTION TO HIGHER HEALTH	2
CHAIRPERSON'S MESSAGE	3
DEPUTY CHAIRPERSON'S MESSAGE	4
SECTION 1: CEO'S OVERVIEW	5
2024 in numbers	7
Launching the Civic and Health Peer Education Programme	7
Knowledge transfer and practical learning for health	8
Accessible youth-friendly health services	10
Strategic directions on gender-based violence	11
Partnerships our strength	11
Funding and financial stability	12
Consolidation of management systems	12
Acknowledgements	13
SECTION 2: OUR STRATEGY AND OPERATIONAL MODEL	14
Strategic Plan 2022-2027	15
New national plan for HIV, TB and STIs	15
Key characteristics of the PSET sector	16
The national PSET landscape	16
HIGHER HEALTH focus areas	17
HIGHER HEALTH Model	17
Structures for delivery	19
National structure of HIGHER HEALTH	19
SECTION 3: DELIVERY OF CORE PROGRAMMES	20
Cross-cutting peer education activities	21
Sexual and Reproductive Health (including HIV, TB and STIs)	22
Access to selected HIV prevention and SRH products and services in 2023	24
Layering care for better effect	25
A watchful eye on NCDs	26
Gender-Based Violence Programme	26
A hearts and minds approach to eliminating GBV	28
Mental Health Programme	29
Creating awareness and combating stigma	29
Self-identification of mental vulnerability	29
Linkage to services	29
Vulnerable Populations Programme	30
Civic and Health Peer Education Programme	30
Universities Programme	33
TVET and CET College Programme	34
Communication and Mass Media Programme	37
SECTION 4: MANAGEMENT REPORT	41
Human Resources	42
Monitoring and Evaluation	43
Risk and Compliance	43
SECTION 5: GOVERNANCE	44
SECTION 6: EXCERPTS FROM ANNUAL FINANCIAL STATEMENTS	47

A brief introduction to HIGHER HEALTH

HIGHER HEALTH is dedicated to promoting the health and wellbeing of students at post-school education and training (PSET) institutions nationwide, thereby contributing to their academic success and life beyond graduation.

We are a non-profit organisation and an implementing agency of the Department of Higher Education and Training (DHET), working in partnership with Universities South Africa (USAf), the representative body of public universities, and the South African Public Colleges Organisation (SAPCO), which represents technical and vocational education and training (TVET) colleges. HIGHER HEALTH also enjoys close collaboration with individual universities, TVET colleges and community education and training (CET) colleges, as well as partners in the health, higher education and vocational training sectors.

MISSION

To contribute to academic success among students in PSET through improving and transforming their health, wellness and psychosocial development.

MANDATES

Mandate 1 Provide technical guidance and leadership in the PSET sector on the health, wellness and psychosocial wellbeing of students.	Mandate 2 Unify the sector response by coordination of stakeholders and role-players.
Mandate 3 Mobilise resources for the sector and for HIGHER HEALTH's activities and operations.	Mandate 4 Undertake sectoral research and the monitoring and evaluation (M&E) of programme impact on student health, wellness and psychosocial development.
Mandate 5 Develop skills and establish capacity building for student health, wellness and psychosocial development in PSET institutions.	Mandate 6 Conduct teaching and learning while overseeing the implementation of relevant service delivery programmes.
Mandate 7 Provide easy access to free health and psychosocial services for students at universities, TVET colleges, and CET learning centres.	

About this annual report

HIGHER HEALTH has prepared this report with our many partners and stakeholders in mind. We appreciate that you may only see the facet of our work closest to you and offer this compact overview to enable you to appreciate how your contribution adds value to our total endeavour.

Our financial year runs from 1 April to 31 March and our financial statements together with matters related to governance and national management of HIGHER HEALTH are reported for the financial year. However, our campus-based programmes are reported mainly for the academic year January to December 2023 because we gear these activities to the campus calendar.

Chairperson's Message

The 2023/24 financial year was a particularly successful one for **HIGHER HEALTH** in terms of programme development, financial stability and corporate consolidation.



The highlight was unquestionably the establishment of the HIGHER HEALTH Academy which is responsible for the conceptualisation and delivery of the accredited Civic and Health Peer Education Programme.

This unique online learning programme, that blends civic awareness with health and wellness education, offers students an opportunity for personal growth that they are unlikely to find in many academic courses. Our aim in higher education is to produce graduates who are not only technically qualified but have the personal attributes to succeed in their careers and contribute to building a better South Africa . . . more equal, more prosperous, more just and at peace with itself. I believe the HIGHER HEALTH Academy will provide momentum towards this goal.

We are very fortunate to have had the backing of the Minister of Higher Education, Science and Innovation, Dr Blade Nzimande, and Deputy Minister Buti Manamela who fully appreciate the vision of HIGHER HEALTH and its potential to enhance the sector.

We envisage the Civic and Health Peer Education Programme will co-exist with HIGHER HEALTH's established offerings. The more options we are able to offer students for engaging with their health and wellbeing, the greater our impact on the campus community is likely to be.

HIGHER HEALTH has advocated passionately over the years for universities and colleges to acknowledge the significant role that physical and mental health plays in the academic success of students. I truly believe that the organisation has won a great deal of support for its approach among institutions in the post-school education and training (PSET) sector.

HIGHER HEALTH's income continued its upward trajectory during the reporting year. Like most non-profit organisations, HIGHER HEALTH relies on grant funding and has learnt to accommodate the fluctuations that this funding model entails. We have been successful in

diversifying our funding sources and have ensured that we are not excessively dependent on any single funder.

At senior management level, after a period some turbulence, the organisation achieved stability in 2023/24 and added the much-needed position of Director: E-learning and Technology to the management structure. Overall, the organisation is lean at the top and fit-for-purpose.

Similarly, the composition of our Board of Directors remained unchanged during the year after some adjustments in 2022/23. Critical role-players in the PSET sector are represented on the Board and their commitment to the organisation is evident and greatly valued.

HIGHER HEALTH's Chief Executive Officer, Professor Ramneek Ahluwalia, has been extraordinarily effective in building partnerships and mobilising resources for the work of the organisation. Consequently, the Board has not faced the difficult financial decisions that frequently confront non-profit organisations. Our oversight role grows increasingly important, however, as budgets, human resources and activities expand. Perhaps our greatest contribution is keeping HIGHER HEALTH closely aligned strategically with the purpose of the PSET sector.

I would like to thank members of the Board for fulfilling their role ably and very willingly. Once again, I salute the creativity and energy that Prof Ahluwalia brings to his role at the head of HIGHER HEALTH. And I wish to recognise the value of every staff member of HIGHER HEALTH, all participating employees at our institutions, and the campus volunteers who help enhance the health and wellbeing of our country's students.

Prof Wim de Villiers
Chairperson

Deputy Chairperson's Message

I would like to express my sincere gratitude to our stakeholders, partners, and supporters for their unwavering dedication and collaboration.



It is with great pleasure that I present the annual report of HIGHER HEALTH for the year 2023/24. As the Deputy Chairperson of the Board, I am honoured to reflect on the past year's achievements and challenges, and the progress we have made in our mission to promote health and wellbeing in the higher education community.

Over the past year, our dedicated team has worked tirelessly to advance our strategic goals and initiatives, despite the challenges we faced during the year. Through our collective efforts and unwavering commitment, we have continued to provide essential health services, resources and support to our stakeholders, including students, faculty and staff across the sector.

The key accomplishments achieved during the year would not have been possible without the hard work and dedication of our staff, partners, and stakeholders. Together, we have made significant strides, and I am proud of what we have accomplished together.

The direct support HIGHER HEALTH provides to students and its expansion into the CET sub-sector which is so often overlooked are remarkable achievements. The availability of nurses on campus and access to our crisis helpline, counsellors and psychologists are a significant support to students at colleges in rural areas, where other services may be inaccessible.

The launch of the Civic and Health Peer Education Programme was a major milestone in our efforts to produce well-rounded, socially responsible graduates. The journey towards successful implementation thereof was a concerted effort by dedicated stakeholders, which makes the achievement even more valuable.

As we look towards the future, we recognise that there are still challenges ahead, and much work to be done to further our mission and vision. I am confident that with continued collaboration, innovation, and a shared commitment to improving the health and wellbeing of our community, we will overcome these challenges and continue to make a positive impact.

We are extremely fortunate to have partners that add new insights to our programmes. The latest of these dynamic relationships is with the United Nations Education, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) and we look forward to the mutual learning that lies ahead.

I would like to express my sincere gratitude to our stakeholders, partners, and supporters for their unwavering dedication and collaboration. Your continued support and engagement are vital to our success, and I look forward to our continued partnership in the years to come.

In closing, I would like to thank the entire HIGHER HEALTH Board for their hard work, passion and commitment to our mission. Together, we will continue to strive for excellence and make a difference in the lives of those we serve.

Prof MDM Phutsisi
Deputy Chairperson



SECTION 1

CHIEF EXECUTIVE OFFICER'S OVERVIEW

Chief Executive Officer's Overview

In 2023/24, our organisation saw a dream become reality when we established the HIGHER HEALTH Academy and 5 467 individuals signed up for the pilot run of our accredited online Civic and Health Peer Education Programme.



We have long been convinced of the link between student empowerment and student health, and this programme is a bold attempt to draw together these streams of development.

Early feedback from participants is that the content of the programme hits the mark, but the digital platform has posed some difficulties. Our commitment is to iron out these technical issues, with the assistance of digital learning experts Anthology, so that future students have a smooth online experience and can focus on the essence of the programme. *(Read more on page 7 and page 31)*

HIGHER HEALTH considers that the Civic and Health Peer Education Programme could become financially self-sustaining and has packaged it as a marketable educational product. We are thrilled that two sector training authorities have responded by providing bursaries for several thousand participants.

In the 2023 academic year, our established model of campus health and wellness continued to benefit students across the country. Our focus, as usual, was on knowledge transfer related to key areas of youth health, opportunities for practical learning about health and wellness, and ensuring linkage to relevant health and psychosocial services, on campus or via our mobile clinics wherever possible.

Standout developments during the year included:

- Initiating a relationship with the United Nations Scientific, Educational and Cultural Organization (UNESCO). This added a new dimension to our gender-based violence (GBV) programme through UNESCO's Transforming MENTalities initiative which focuses on changing perceptions and values among men to create a culture that enables gender equality.

It is, if you like, the flipside of empowerment initiatives among women, and equally important. UNESCO has also shown a strong interest in the HIGHER HEALTH Academy and we are hopeful that our engagement will expand in months to come.

- Collaborating with the National Prosecuting Authority (NPA) to forge common approaches to GBV and related matters, such as sexual harassment. This teamwork was facilitated by the Ministries of Higher Education, Science and Innovation and Justice and Correctional Services. We will soon be able to announce joint projects that will directly benefit campus communities.
- Strengthening access to psychosocial services by:
 - Adding registered counsellors to the healthcare teams operating from our provincial offices and selected campuses.
 - Improving access to follow-up care for users of our 24-hour crisis helpline, which responded to 12 550 calls and messages during 2023. Thanks to a new reporting system, students needing further psychosocial services can be identified more quickly and referred to a psychologist or counsellor.
 - Creating a crisis team at head office that specialises in assisting institutional management when traumatic events – such as fatal traffic collisions, criminal attacks, femicide or suicide – directly affect campus communities. This team is dispatched to the institution to guide management on communication, counselling and other forms of support to campus colleagues and students.
- The substantial contribution of our fleet of 10 mobile clinics to screening for communicable and non-communicable diseases and the provision of sexual and reproductive health (SRH) services. For

2024 IN NUMBERS

HIGHER HEALTH serves **1.8 million students** at 32 public universities, 50 TVET colleges and nine CET colleges

Knowledge transfer

Total attendance at interactive **CoCurriculum sessions: 239 619**. Main topics: mental health, sexual and reproductive health (and HIV, TB and STIs), and gender-based violence

Registration for online **Civic and Health Peer Education Programme** pilot: **5 467** staff and students

Partners in **Future Beats** youth radio initiative: 22 campus and community stations with about **1 million listeners**

Student agency for health

Total **health risk self-assessments** completed by students: **248 486**

HIV tests and screenings requested for TB, STIs, non-communicable diseases and cancers: **676 312**

Students volunteering as **peer educators: 2 140**

Participation in **Mandela-Sobukwe Leadership Retreat** in Cape Town: **130** peer educators

Health products and services

Condoms distributed: **4.3 million**

Referred for or provided care:

- **16 055 for PrEP**, the daily HIV prevention pill
- **108 004 for contraceptives** of their choice
- **2 842 for medical male circumcision**
- **620 students** living with HIV for **ARV treatment**

Mental health services

Helpline calls and messages: **12 550**

Sessions by **HH psychologists: 13 821**

On-campus psychosocial support: **7 122**

example, 14% of all HIV tests in the sector and 20% of non-communicable disease (NCD) screenings were performed at our mobile clinics.

- An encouraging vote of confidence from our funding partners who renewed, and in some cases substantially increased, their funding of HIGHER HEALTH. Our total income for the year was R109 million, a healthy 17% increase on the previous year.
- A concerted effort to strengthen corporate risk management and compliance through measures like a comprehensive audit of human resources and IT equipment, publication of our information manual in accordance with the Promotion of Access to Information Act, and compliance with the Protection of Personal Information Act.
- Improvement of our monitoring and evaluation (M&E) systems with progress towards real-time digital reporting that integrates all provincial offices and allows institutions direct access to their own data.

Launching the Civic and Health Peer Education Programme

The formation of the HIGHER HEALTH Academy rested on the Quality Council on Trades and Occupations' (QCTO) accreditation of the Civic and Health Peer Education Programme and recognition of our organisation as a service provider for this programme.

The programme takes our efforts to empower students through their engagement with health and wellbeing to a new level. Not only is the content more extensive, but the formal education platform enables us to measure the programme's impact on every participant. Furthermore, it rewards those who successfully complete the modules with a recognised NQF Level 5 skills certificate.

The foundation module of the programme deals with civics. It invites participants to examine what it means to live and thrive in a democratic society, unpacking the rights and responsibilities of the individual. This theme of engaged citizenship is carried through the rest of the programme.

During recent months, two modules dealing with financial literacy and climate change were added to the original six-module programme. This expanded programme will be known as the Civic and Soft Skills Programme and is currently undergoing accreditation.

Chief Executive Officer's Overview *continued*

As shown in the graphic below, the eight modules of the expanded programme address topics directly related to several of the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). Our approach to health imparts the skills for self-care and for enabling the wellbeing of others. The programme also builds generic workplace skills, complementing the more technical content of the degree or diploma courses students are enrolled in and preparing them for the transition to the world of work.

Content of expanded Civic and Soft Skills Programme, links to SDGs and workplace skills

Mandate 3 Civic Education		Mandate 5 Comprehensive Sexuality Education		Workplace Skills • Empathy, listening and counselling • Civic responsibility • Conflict resolution • Creativity, critical thinking and problem solving • Decision making • Digital literacy • Communication • Resilience and self-motivation • Teamwork and leadership skills • Time management and goal setting
Mandate 2 Gender-Transformative Education		Mandate 6 Substance Abuse and Building Resilience		
Mandate 3 Mental Health		Mandate 7 Climate Change		
Mandate 4 Disability		Mandate 8 Financial Literacy		

Note: Each module has been linked to the SDG with which it has the strongest connection. But several modules – most notably the one dealing with climate change – connect to more than one SDG.

We believe the programme is a steppingstone towards a more caring, inclusive and equitable society. Initiatives such as this can help our nation overcome the residual effects of apartheid and discover the cohesion that has so far eluded us.

Details on the pilot run of the original six-module programme can be found on page 31.

Knowledge transfer and practical learning for health

HIGHER HEALTH targets the areas of health and wellness that most adolescent and youth health programmes prioritise, namely: sexual and reproductive health (SRH), including HIV; mental health and wellness; gender-based violence (GBV); substance misuse; and health-related and psychosocial issues of LGBTQI students and those with disabilities.

We take a positive approach to promoting health and wellness, with a strong emphasis on healthy living,

preventing illness, and intervening early when problems are detected. In short, we encourage students to take responsibility for their health as they begin to assume adult roles. We also influence the social environment of campuses, through campaigns, health days and other forms of dialogue, to encourage a culture of care and respect that is conducive to health.

Knowledge transfer on health and wellness takes place through a variety of interventions organised by HIGHER HEALTH in partnership with universities and colleges.

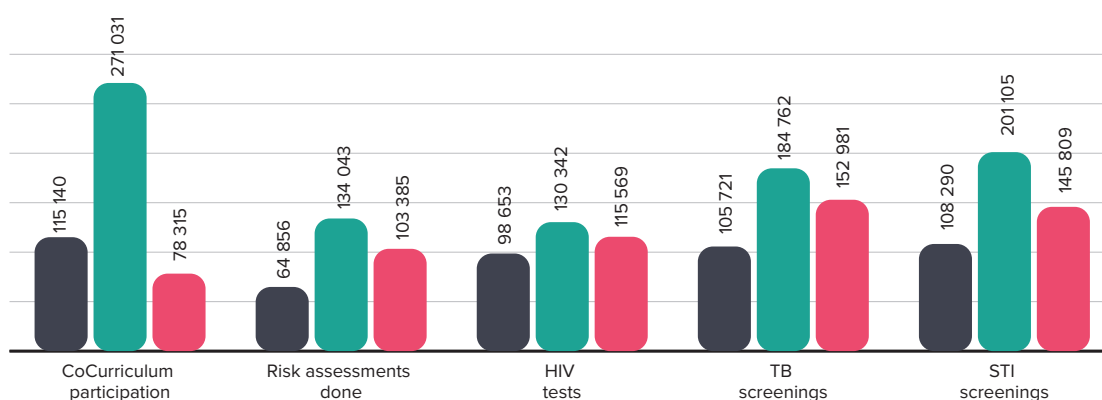
The least formal of these are health and wellness days held under the slogan, First Things First. During these events peer educators generate awareness of relevant health matters and students have an opportunity to test for HIV and screen for other health conditions. Public sector and non-profit partners in the community often join in health and wellness days, enhancing health promotion activities and expanding screening options. In 2023, a total of 950 health days were organised.

Also part of our informal learning is the Future Beats radio initiative, involving the broadcast of health and wellness content by campus radio stations and community radio stations serving localities with large student populations. In 2023 a total of 22 stations with a collective listenership of about one million regularly provided health information and facilitated discussions on issues affecting health. HIGHER HEALTH provides modest sponsorship to the stations and guidance on health content.

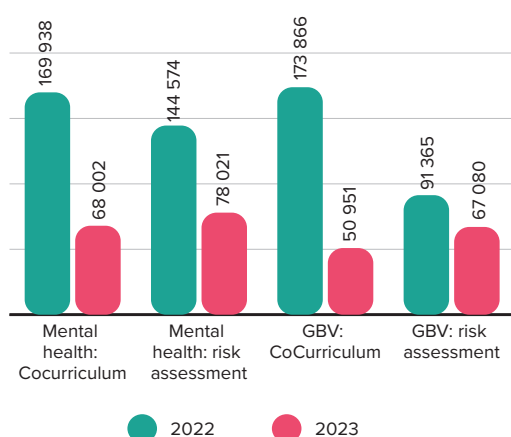
More formal education takes place through the CoCurriculum, which comprises different modules such as HIV, TB and SRH; mental health; and GBV. Each module is facilitated in a seated, classroom session by a campus health and wellness coordinator (CHWC) at TVET and CET colleges and by a peer educator at universities. Total participation in the CoCurriculum, across all subjects, was 237 619 in 2023.

Lastly, since late 2023, HIGHER HEALTH has been able to offer its accredited Civic and Health Peer Education Programme (described above) as its most intensive knowledge transfer instrument, allowing formal measurement of understanding gained by participants.

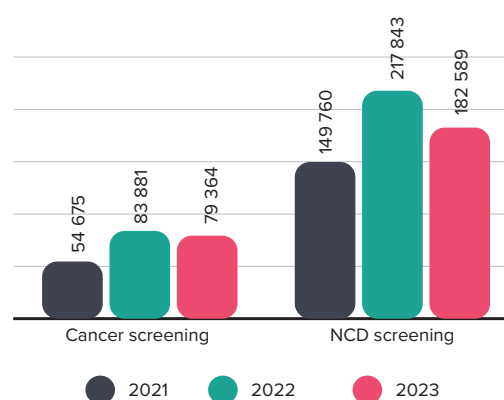
Participation in prevention activities: HIV, TB, STIs and SRH



Participation in prevention activities: mental health and GBV



Uptake of other health screening services



Note: 2021 figures are not comparable as the two modules were combined at that stage.

Chief Executive Officer's Overview *continued*

The most significant practical learning activity HIGHER HEALTH promotes on campus is students' use of a self-assessment tool to understand their individual risk for specific health conditions. These self-assessments may be done in various circumstances – at a health day, in a clinic, or at the end of a CoCurriculum session.

In 2023, the total number of self-assessments completed by students was 248 486. HIV, TB and SRH self-assessments amounted to 103 385, outstripping the figures for mental health (78 021) and GBV (67 080).

Overall, fewer students engaged in knowledge transfer and practical learning activities in 2023 than in the previous year. This was partly because the 2022 numbers were extraordinarily high, probably due to a bounce-back factor as the PSET sector put COVID-19 behind it. In addition, our grant-based funding occasionally creates downtime during which our recruitment and training of peer educators is constrained, our employment of CHWCs is temporarily reduced, and payment of stipends to peer mentors is curtailed. Since our model depends critically on face-to-face engagement with students, any reduction in human power has knock-on effects.

Uptake of HIV testing and clinical screening for communicable and non-communicable diseases was satisfactory in 2023 with more than 670 000 tests or screenings performed.

Accessible youth-friendly health services

Since the post-COVID return to normality, HIGHER HEALTH has worked steadily to recover the progress we had made pre-pandemic in developing youth-appropriate health services on campuses. Cooperation with campus health services and provincial and district health departments is central to this process and in 2023 we felt that these partnerships were back on track.

Ideally, we would like to see all campus clinics and our mobile fleet able to provide contraceptives, oral pre-exposure prophylaxis (PrEP), antiretroviral treatment (ART) in stable cases, STI diagnosis and treatment, and TB medication. Presently, campus and mobile clinics mostly refer students for these services, either to public health clinics or to other non-profit organisations that have been funded to strengthen HIV and SRH services in particular health districts. With training of their staff and the provision of supplies by the health district, campus and mobile facilities could provide this care more conveniently for students.

In the past year, we worked toward the signing of formal memorandums of understanding with provincial and district health authorities. Public health providers also conducted training for HIGHER HEALTH nurses on HIV counselling and testing, in accordance with national guidelines.

The figures from our HIV and SRH services pose some questions.

- We distributed about 4.3 million condoms in 2023. While this remained a significant quantity it was one-third less than the year before, due mainly to limited availability of stock nationally.
- Condoms are the only prevention tool that delivers triple value by preventing HIV, other STIs and pregnancy. In 2023, as condom availability declined, we saw a rise in students presenting with STIs and requesting referrals for termination of pregnancy.
- We also saw increased demand for alternative methods of HIV prevention, such as voluntary medical male circumcision (VMMC) and oral pre-exposure prophylaxis (PrEP).
- The demand for contraception was similar to the previous year.

The links between these developments are not firmly established. But we need to be alert to the need to assist students to understand their HIV and SRH risks and requirements in a holistic manner.

In contrast to medical services, psychosocial services for students are mostly provided directly by universities, colleges or HIGHER HEALTH. This role is shared by student clinics and counselling services at institutions, HIGHER HEALTH's mobile clinics, psychologists and registered counsellors, and the 24-hour multilingual crisis helpline we run in partnership with the South African Depression and Anxiety Group (SADAG).

In 2023, there was a slight increase in requests for psychosocial support. Analysis of service data indicates that:

- Academic stress is the leading reason for students seeking help, followed by anxiety and depression.
- University students are more likely than TVET and CET college students to be at risk of mental health problems.

Strategic direction on GBV

GBV is an especially complex area demanding intervention on many fronts. HIGHER HEALTH has played a vital role in enabling institutions to tackle the issue by sourcing technical expertise, drafting policy frameworks, guidelines and protocols, and training management, staff and student leadership in the implementation of these approaches. Campus health and psychosocial services have also built capacity to assist students who have experienced GBV or feel they are at risk.

In the reporting year, we took steps to drive the participation of men in dismantling a patriarchal culture which devalues women by affiliating to the UNESCO Transforming MENTalities initiative.

- In August 2023, HIGHER HEALTH co-convened a Transforming MENTalities Summit attended by 965 representatives from the PSET sector. The participation of Minister of Higher Education, Science and Innovation Dr Blade Nzimande, Minister in the Presidency for Women, Children and Persons with Disabilities Dr Nkosana Dlamini-Zuma, and UNESCO's Assistant Director-General for Human and Social Sciences, Gabriela Ramos, signalled our seriousness about this strategic approach.
- In January 2024 I was fortunate to attend the UNESCO NGO Forum on Transforming MENTalities in Paris and in March that year presented our Civic and Health Peer Education Programme to a meeting of the Global Education Coalition.
- In February 2024 we welcomed a delegation from UNESCO to our head office to share our broader programme of work and identify potential areas of collaboration.
- At the UNESCO Executive Board meeting in March, South Africa – spurred on by HIGHER HEALTH – sponsored a resolution on Transforming MENTalities. This was supported by 77 countries and HIGHER HEALTH became a UNESCO partner for implementing the resolution globally.

As a health programme within an educational environment, we feel that our fit with UNESCO is natural, and we are hopeful that our engagements of the last year will have long-lasting, mutual benefits.

Partnerships our strength

With our fairly modest staff complement of about 170, HIGHER HEALTH is only able to support a programme for 1.8 million students through well-articulated partnerships with like-minded organisations that provide essential human and financial resources.

The bedrock of HIGHER HEALTH's programmes is the partnership forged with institutions comprising the PSET sector: the public universities, TVET colleges, and CET colleges and learning centres. Most human resources that power health and wellness activities on campuses are drawn directly from the institutions. We rely on their management, staff and student volunteers for the energy, creativity and service ethic that persuade the broad student body to put First Things First and deal proactively with their health and wellbeing.

HIGHER HEALTH also enjoys a harmonious relationship with the Department of Higher Education and Training (DHET) and has benefited immensely from the public endorsement of our activities by the Minister of Higher Education, Science and Innovation Dr Blade Nzimande and Deputy Minister Buti Manamela.

Funding partnerships are equally critical to HIGHER HEALTH's ability to fulfil its role in the sector. To date, HIGHER HEALTH has been entirely funded by grants from global funding organisations, South African government departments and other public entities, and occasional private sector donations. We are particularly grateful to funders in the education and training sector that have made the leap of faith and seen value in the development of health skills. Their ability to work cross-sectorally has greatly enabled the expansion of our work.

Increasingly, HIGHER HEALTH depends on valuable technical partnerships as we seek to innovate. Historically, our work in relation to GBV and our ability to play a role in defending against the COVID-19 pandemic were enabled by experts in these fields. Now, as we venture into the field of formal digital education, partners with experience in this very rich field have come to our assistance. We simply could not have moved forward without them.

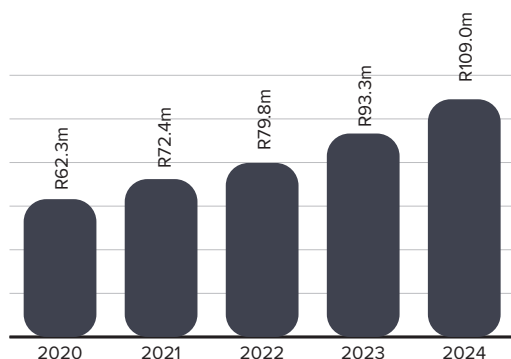
Finally there are the operational partnerships with organisations that are willing to join us as we service the country's student population. They include roleplayers in the public health sector, from the national department right down to local clinics. They also include non-profit organisations in the field of HIV and TB care and SRH who are funded to help health districts expand their clinical services. These are the facilities to which HIGHER HEALTH refers students for HIV and TB treatment, for prevention options such as pre-exposure prophylaxis (PrEP) and voluntary medical male circumcision (VMMC), and a range of SRH care.

Chief Executive Officer's Overview *continued*

Funding and financial stability

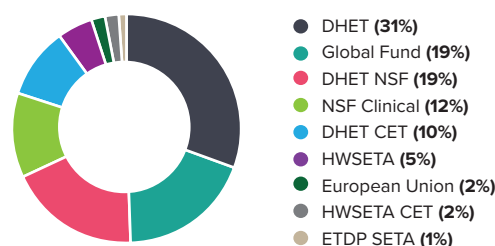
HIGHER HEALTH has seen steady growth in its annual income and in 2023/24 our total income of R109 million exceeded the previous year's amount by a substantial R15.7 million, representing year-on-year growth of nearly 17%.

Growth in HIGHER HEALTH income 2020–2024



This growth is partly due to our ability to diversify our sources of funding. HIGHER HEALTH's holistic approach to health and wellness and the fact that we span the health and educational sectors mean that we have synergy with a range of grant-making institutions. We are fortunate to have retained several funders over the years and believe that our respect for their processes and attention to reporting requirements have played a part in preserving these valued relationships.

Sources of grant funding 2023/24



Note: Grants amounting to less than 1% of the total have not been included in this figure.

HIGHER HEALTH ended the year with an operating surplus of R3.96 million. Human resources costs accounted for 53% of expenditure, while 35% was absorbed by programme implementation and 12% by administrative costs.

Summary of income and expenditure

	2024	2023
Revenue	109 005 130	93 322 641
Other operating income	3 026 106	897 385
Other operating gains (losses)	(160 819)	(3 742)
Other operating expenses	(109 624 967)	(97 629 731)
Operating (loss) or profit	2 245 450	(3 413 447)
Finance costs	(703 268)	(172 389)
Fair value gains/losses	1 531 508	1 082 247
Surplus/(loss) for the year	3 073 690	(2 503 589)

* The restatement of certain 2023 figures is explained in the financial statements at the end of this report.

HIGHER HEALTH ended the year with an operating surplus of R3.07million. Human resources costs accounted for 53% of expenditure, while 35% was absorbed by programme implementation and 12% by administrative costs.

Consolidation of management systems

HIGHER HEALTH recognises that increased funding and our growing scope of work demand robust management capacity and systems and I am happy to report several developments.

Importantly, our senior management team was stabilised through several appointments and is working as an effective and cohesive group. Our managers have had to handle the ending of some grants – with resultant human resources cut-backs – along with the growth of new initiatives. This complexity is challenging, and I commend the manner in which our teams at our national, regional and provincial offices have responded.

We paid special attention to risk and compliance functions during the year. Among the steps taken was a staff and IT audit, which confirmed that all employees on the payroll were in fact performing their designated roles and IT equipment issued was fully accounted for. We also ensured compliance with the Promotion of Access to Information Act and the Protection of Personal Information Act.

Our M&E framework has been adjusted to ensure full alignment with our five-year strategy. We continue to make progress towards real-time digital reporting across the three sub-sectors. However, this is a process and the system we develop must be suited to realities on the ground in order to yield data that is both accurate and current.

Acknowledgments

HIGHER HEALTH's coordination of the PSET sector's health and wellness response relies on the goodwill and expertise of many role-players who have the interests of institutions and students at heart. I extend my deep appreciation to each and every one of you.

While I cannot acknowledge every individual contribution, I would like to mention some of our major supporters.

We are grateful to Minister Nzimande for his constant interest and significant participation in the life of HIGHER HEALTH and to Deputy Minister Buti Manamela who has been an unflagging advocate of student health and wellness over many years. We also wish to mention the contribution of officials of the DHET who facilitate our programmes.

We appreciate the support of vice-chancellors of universities and principals of TVET and CET colleges and the hands-on contribution of diverse members of management and staff at institutions across the country. We are also grateful to Universities South Africa (USaf) and the South African Public Colleges Organisation (SAPCO) which enable our work and provide valuable guidance through representation on our Board.

We would like to recognise the important role of student leadership, peer educators, and campus and community radio stations in mobilising campuses in support of health and wellness.

We are deeply appreciative of our funders who have not only provided financial resources but taken time to understand HIGHER HEALTH and been willing to invest in novel approaches to health promotion that build on the unique assets of the PSET sector.

During the past year, our Civic and Health Peer Education Programme moved from concept to reality and its successor, the Civic and Soft Skills Programme, was developed. I specifically want to mention those partners who helped make this happen: the QCTO, the Health and Welfare SETA, the Education, Training and Development Practices SETA, digital education experts Anthology and OneConnect, and University of Johannesburg who lent us a digital platform for several months.

At service-delivery level, campus health services and our mobile clinic fleet receive invaluable assistance from provincial and district health services as well as non-governmental and community-based organisations. We would like to thank them for their collegial cooperation.

Next to last, I wish to thank members of the HIGHER HEALTH Board who get the mixture of encouragement, realistic guidance and oversight just right. It is reassuring to have such a Board in our corner during these exciting times of expansion and exploration.

And finally, to my management team and all staff members of HIGHER HEALTH, 2023/24 was a year of change and such periods make heavy demands on us. I wish to thank you for your dedication and the strength you bring to our work. To those who left us during 2023, especially the cohort of CHWCs whose fixed-term contracts ended: thank you for your pioneering work with us. HIGHER HEALTH and the PSET sector have benefited enormously and we are sure you have emerged wiser and more skilled. We wish you the best as you take on new roles.

Dr (Prof) Ramneek Ahluwalia

Chief Executive Officer

Remembering Anuysha

On 21 May 2024, Anuysha Naidu, former Executive Manager in the CEO's Office, lost her battle with cancer. Many of you will remember Anuysha as the calm centre of the storm during COVID-19 as she played a key role in coordinating the sector response. Ignoring her own health risks, she travelled to institutions across the country and kept our email inboxes active beyond midnight. During the COVID years she was diagnosed with cancer which forced her early retirement. Anuysha met many setbacks with resolve in her determination to live and, ultimately, with grace as she succumbed to her illness at the young age of 54. Her legacy lives on in HIGHER HEALTH. Box ends





SECTION 2

OUR STRATEGY AND OPERATIONAL MODEL

Our Strategy and Operational Model

HIGHER HEALTH offers health and wellness programmes within the unique environment of the post-school education and training (PSET) sector. At a strategic level our goals converge with the PSET sector's purpose of producing successful graduates who are well qualified to meet the challenges of our society.

HIGHER HEALTH focuses on preventing and treating physical and psychosocial conditions that impede students' ability to study and advance through the academic programme. We also aim to enrich students' learning experiences by building health awareness, self-care skills and the personal agency to take action in the interests of their wellbeing and that of the student community more broadly.

We also contribute to achieving the goals of national initiatives that intersect with our focus areas, such as the National Strategic Plan for HIV, TB and STIs and the National Strategic Plan against Gender-Based Violence and Femicide.

Strategic Plan 2022–2027

In the past year, HIGHER HEALTH has geared its efforts to actualising the goals contained in our Strategic Plan 2022–2027.

- Goal 1** Through health awareness-creation, improve the knowledge of students to increase health-seeking behaviour which may contribute to timely completion of their studies.
- Goal 2** Provide capacity building and skills training on health, wellness and psychosocial policy guidelines for staff at HIGHER HEALTH and PSET institutions.
- Goal 3** Provide accessible, quality health and psychosocial support services to students across the PSET sector.
- Goal 4** Expand HIGHER HEALTH's teaching and learning through extramural Co-Curriculum courses that build health and wellness knowledge and skills of students.
- Goal 5** Contribute to the development of an institutional environment that respects human rights and promotes responsible citizenship as a foundation for student health, wellness and psychosocial development.
- Goal 6** Maintain HIGHER HEALTH's funding base through a sustainable revenue model.
- Goal 7** Strengthen and expand partnerships with institutions in all PSET sub-sectors, relevant government departments, funding and donor agencies, and other stakeholders in the broad field of student health, wellness and psychosocial development.

Goal 8 Promote the use of social and traditional media and digital communication to create awareness of the social and structural determinants of health.

The relevance of these goals to HIGHER HEALTH's everyday work is evident throughout this report.

New national plan for HIV, TB and STIs

During the year the National Strategic Plan for HIV, TB and STIs 2023–2028 (NSP 2023–2028) came into effect. Major themes of the new plan are reducing barriers to accessing health and social services, empowering communities, and respect for human rights. The significance of mental health services in the HIV response has been highlighted for the first time.

The plan is structured around four goals:

- **Goal 1:** Break down barriers to achieving solutions for HIV, TB and STIs.
- **Goal 2:** Maximise equitable and equal access to services and solutions for HIV, TB and STIs.
- **Goal 3:** Fully resource and sustain an efficient NSP led by revitalised, inclusive and accountable institutions.
- **Goal 4:** Build resilient systems for HIV, TB and STIs that are integrated into systems for health, social protection and pandemic response.

HIGHER HEALTH's holistic approach to health and wellness harmonises with this new NSP. The plan validates our emphasis on gender-based violence (GBV) and gender equity, mental health and an activist approach to health.

A significant addition to the NSP that we need to consider is viral hepatitis as a neglected infection linked to HIV and STIs, with high prevalence and lifelong consequences.

Our Strategy and Operational Model *continued*

Key characteristics of the PSET sector

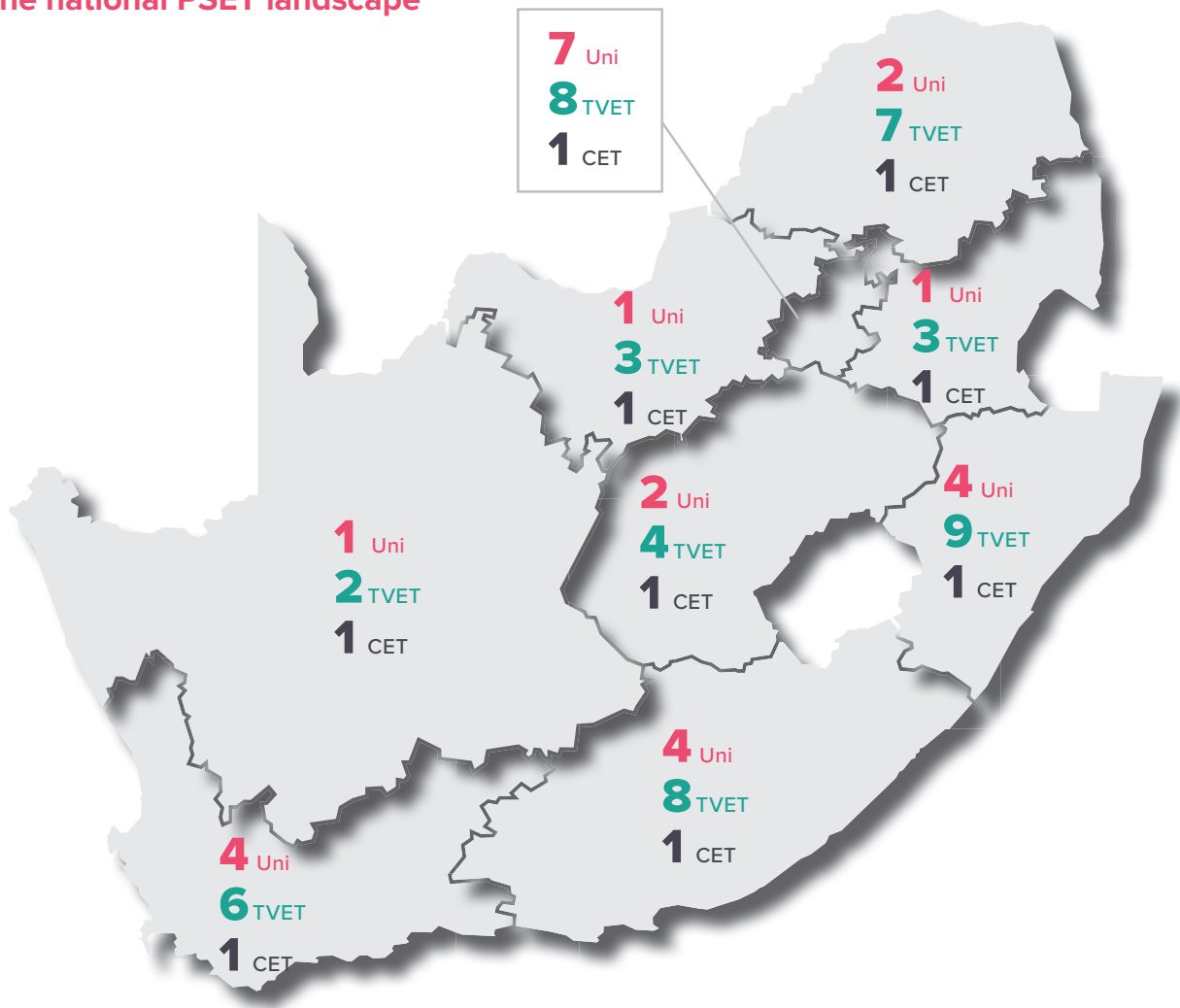
Our strategy and operational planning are shaped by the nature of the community we serve – the 1 800 160 students enrolled at public universities, TVET colleges and CET colleges (Source: DHET Statistics on Post-School Education 2021). Of these students, 59% attended universities, 33% TVET colleges and 8% CET colleges.

The university sub-sector consists of large campuses, the majority of which are in metro or large urban areas. Colleges in the TVET sub-sector are typically smaller

and more dispersed, with a number of campuses in rural areas. The CET sub-sector comprises one college per province, with a large number of community learning centres and hundreds of satellite centres scattered countrywide and accommodated mainly in school premises.

About a quarter of PSET students are enrolled in institutions in Gauteng, a further quarter are enrolled in KwaZulu-Natal and Western Cape institutions, while the remaining 50% are distributed unevenly across the remaining six provinces.

The national PSET landscape



	Public universities	TVET colleges	CET colleges
Institutions	26	50	9
Campuses/sites/learning centres	108	311	200*
Campuses reached by HH	108	250	168
Students	1 068 046	589 083**	143 031

Notes:
 * With 1591 satellite centres, as per notice in 2020 Government Gazette 43654
 ** TVET college enrolment increased 30% in 2021 from previous year, normalising figures after COVID-related decline in enrolment in 2020
 Source: Statistics on post-school education in South Africa 2020. DHET, Pretoria, 2023

Women constitute a majority of the PSET student population. In the university and TVET college sub-sectors they account for about 60% of students, and the proportion increases to over 70% in the CET sub-sector.

While students in the PSET sector can generally be characterised as young people, there is a degree of diversity within and among sub-sectors. Students under the age of 25 years comprise 61% of the total enrolment at universities, 69% at TVET colleges, and 45% at CET centres. HIGHER HEALTH's interventions are intended mainly for the health needs of the youth – as our focus areas set out in the box in the box below indicate – but some flexibility is in-built.

HIGHER HEALTH focus areas

Mental health

Awareness, addressing stigma, risk assessment, access to psychosocial services.

Gender-based violence

Awareness, risk assessment, early intervention, support groups, access to clinical and psychosocial services.

Sexual and reproductive health

Contraception, pregnancy testing, access to antenatal care and termination services, and prevention and early detection of certain cancers.

HIV, tuberculosis (TB) and sexually transmitted infections (STIs)

Awareness, risk assessment, screening and testing, prevention methods, access to treatment and support systems.

LGBTQI+ health

Awareness, promotion of rights, support groups, responsive health systems.

Harmful use of alcohol and drugs

Awareness, risk assessment, combating stigma, linkage to specialised services.

Health of people with disabilities

Awareness, advocacy and promotion of rights, support groups.

The HIGHER HEALTH Model

HIGHER HEALTH's support to students on university and college campuses has been informed by a model that consists of three levels of intervention: knowledge transfer, practical learning, and linking students to health and psychosocial services.

Level 1

Knowledge transfer: Sharing relevant information on health and health living, within a supportive environment, is the first step to enabling students to take care of their wellbeing. Knowledge transfer includes awareness-raising activities and events undertaken by student volunteers and peer educators, as well as more structured health education modules delivered through the extramural Co-Curriculum. A third element in the HIGHER HEALTH package is the Future Beats radio and social media programme which enables campus and relevant community stations to carry regular health content and encourages debate on the social, cultural and economic factors that impact on student health and wellness.

Level 2

Practical learning. This flows from knowledge transfer and involves students applying their new understanding of an aspect of health to their own circumstances and behaviour. They do this by means of a self-administered assessment which indicates whether they are at risk of illness or harm. The system ensures that students who are at high risk of acquiring HIV, for example, or developing a mental health condition, or being subjected to partner violence can seek advice immediately and, if necessary, be referred for professional help.

Level 3

Linking students to health and psychosocial services. These services include the toll-free crisis hotline for psychosocial support, more extensive professional counselling, and clinical services in the areas of HIV and TB prevention and treatment, sexual and reproductive health (SRH), and non-communicable diseases (NCDs). Some services are offered by campus health clinics and HIGHER HEALTH's mobile clinics, while others are accessed by referral to community health services.

Our Strategy and Operational Model *continued*

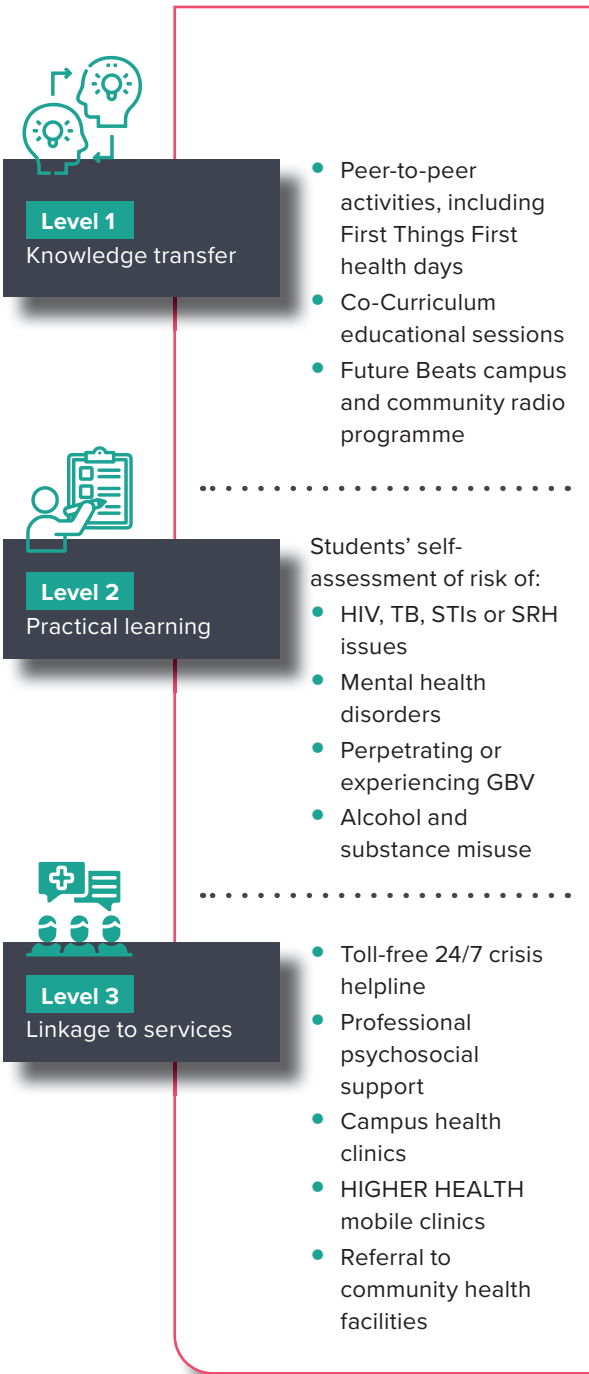
Over the years, implementation of the HIGHER HEALTH Model and the process of recruiting and training peer educators as co-implementers of the model, has deepened our conviction that the key to preventive health lies in empowerment or developing the individual's agency. We have also found that change at a community and societal level may be needed to enable this individual growth.

These insights have led to three significant HIGHER HEALTH work streams that complement our model:

- The development of sector-wide policies and guidelines designed to contribute to a health-promoting climate at every PSET institution and extensive training for institutional staff on the implementation of these policies and guidelines.
- The launch of our digital, accredited Civic and Health Peer Education Programme which takes both knowledge transfer and practical learning to a higher level and develops the link between active citizenship and health.
- A renewed effort to ensure convenient access to youth-friendly health and psychosocial services through a combination of institution-run, public health sector, NGO and HIGHER HEALTH clinics and counselling services.



The HIGHER HEALTH Model



Structures for delivery

The structure of HIGHER HEALTH is designed to ensure that relevant staff members are accessible to every public university and TVET college in the country and an increasing number of CET learning centres.

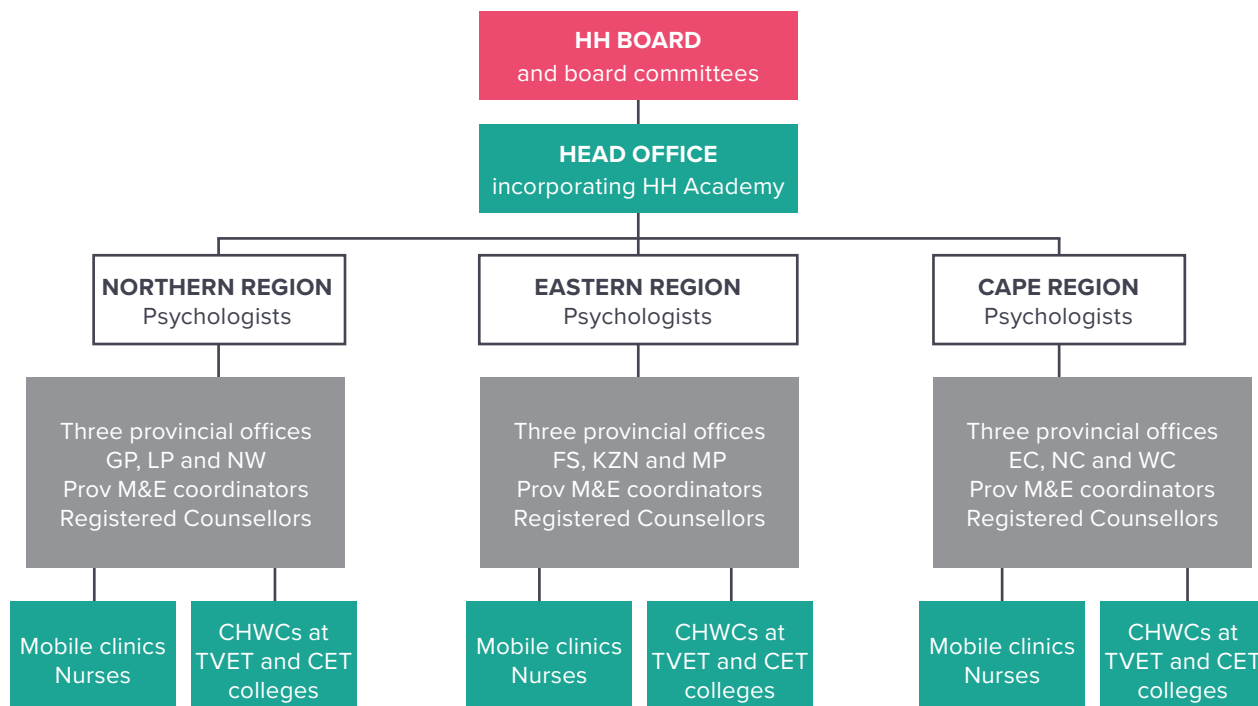
The national management team is located at our head office in Tshwane, together with the HIGHER HEALTH Academy, the nerve centre of the Civic and Health Peer Education Programme.

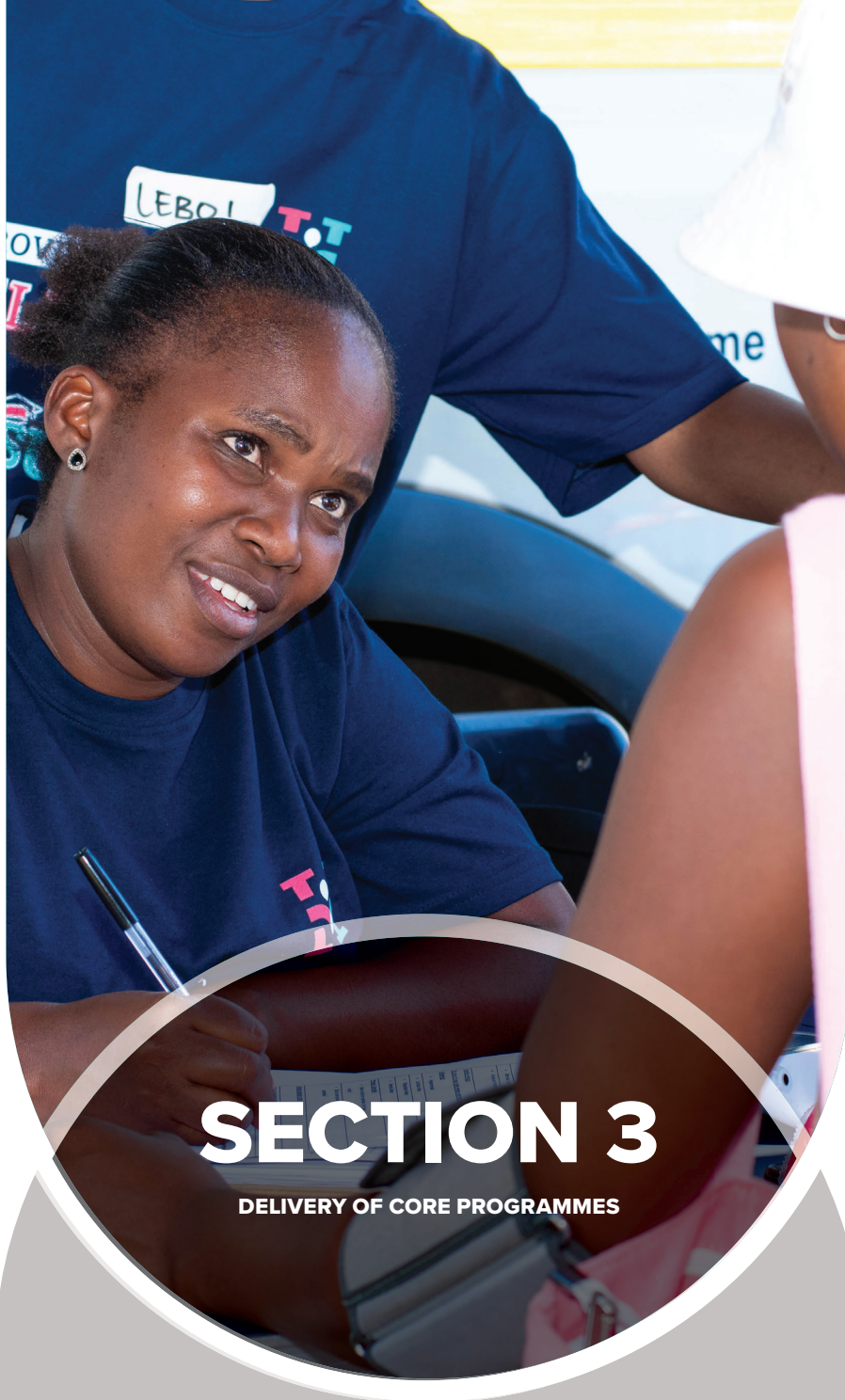
Our regional and provincial offices are key to providing direct support to TVET colleges and CET learning

centres. Not only are campus health and wellness coordinators (CHWCs) seconded from provincial offices to work at individual TVET colleges and clusters of CET learning centres, but important health and psychosocial resources are managed from regional and provincial offices. The 10 mobile clinics – staffed by a professional nurse and enrolled nurse – are dispatched from these offices to campuses and clinical psychologists conduct their consultations from our regional offices, often using digital meeting platforms.

The chain of management and reporting is secured by clustering provinces into three regions, the managers of which are directly accountable to head office.

National structure of HIGHER HEALTH





SECTION 3

DELIVERY OF CORE PROGRAMMES

Delivery of Core Programmes

The delivery of HIGHER HEALTH programmes is shaped largely by the academic calendar of universities and colleges. Awareness-raising activities, along with recruitment and training of peer educators, tend to occur earlier in the year with a strong focus on student registration and induction weeks. Clinical and psychosocial services must be available throughout the year to meet students' needs as they arise. Disruptions to campus life – in the form of student protests and class boycotts – inevitably impact HIGHER HEALTH's output and our ability to serve students.

Overall, we saw a decline in the number of students engaging in health education and risk-screening activities in 2023. This is concerning, because our model is strongly geared to health promotion and the prevention illness, which required the active participation of the student community.

The reason for this dip in performance was that some grants that enabled HIGHER HEALTH to recruit and train peer educators, remunerate peer mentors, and employ campus health and wellness coordinators (CHWCs) came to an end during the reporting period. Although new grants were subsequently awarded, there were temporary funding gaps that impacted on the delivery of activities at campus level.

A key objective of a major National Skills Fund (NSF) grant was to provide time-limited employment to young people in entry-level positions to enhance their competitiveness in the job market. Many of HIGHER HEALTH's campus health and wellness coordinators (CHWCs) were employed through this scheme on contracts that could not exceed three years.

In contrast, students' use of various services – SRH, HIV, mental health and GBV – was at least on a par with 2022 and, in some instances, exceeded last year's uptake. We have begun to record the contribution of our mobile clinics separately within our monitoring and evaluation (M&E) system and the figures confirm their solid performance.

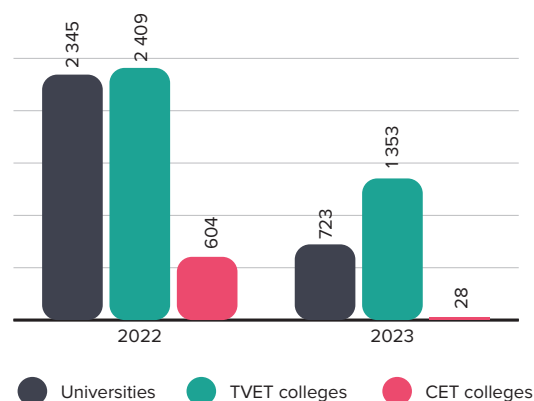
An entirely new offering that came to fruition in 2023 is the Civic and Health Peer Education Programme. This standalone certificate programme underwent pilot testing during the reporting period with more than 4 200 young people participating in this trial run. It represents an exciting new way for students to think about active citizenship and its place in health and wellness.

Cross-cutting peer education activities

Peer-to-peer education is a major element of most of our programmes and, at the start of each academic year, a new cohort of peer educators is recruited and trained at every university and college. Appropriate staff members at institutions serve as mentors to peer educators.

In 2023, the number of peer educators – a total of 2 104 for the entire sector – declined considerably compared to previous years, due to the transition from one grant cycle to the next.

Number of peer educators and mobilisers trained



Training for peer educators covers essential facts related to HIGHER HEALTH's priority health and wellness areas, the building of communication skills and sharing of values that our organisation embodies.

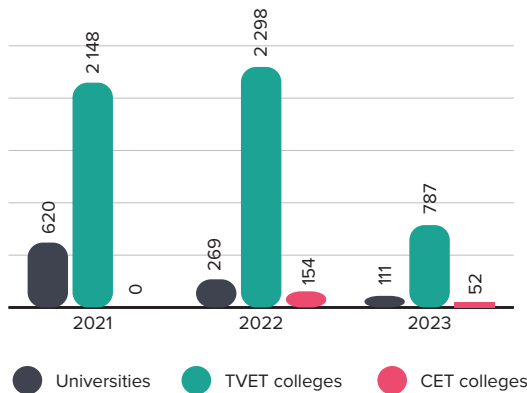
At TVET and CET colleges peer educators and peer mobilisers work closely with CHWCs, who perform the more complex facilitation functions involved in offering the Co-Curriculum. At universities, peer educators are also entrusted with facilitating Co-Curriculum sessions.

Delivery of Core Programmes *continued*

Peer educators are central to the organisation of health and wellness days on campus. These events are usually branded as First Things First and offer students health information and the opportunity to undergo testing and screening for various health conditions. A single "health day" may occur over a few days at major university campuses to accommodate the larger demand for testing and screening.

The total number of health and wellness days held in 2023 was 950, a mere 35% of the number organised the previous year. This was a consequence of the transition between grants.

Number of health and wellness days held on campus

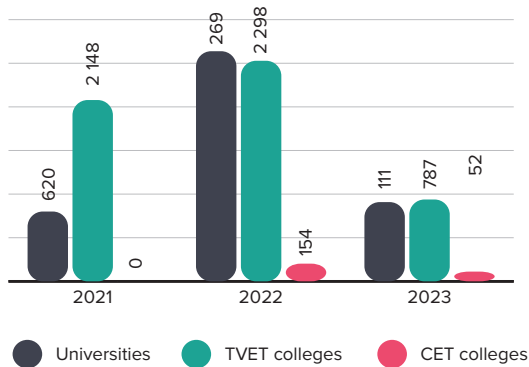


Sexual and Reproductive Health including HIV, TB and STIs

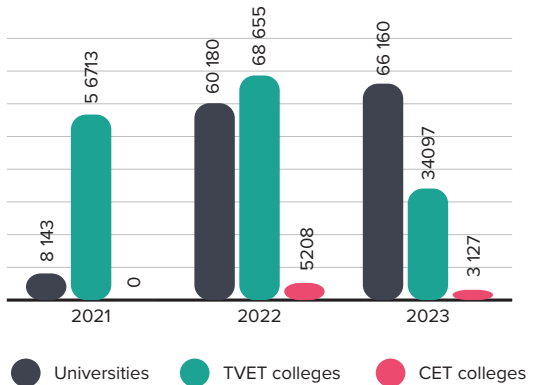
Enabling students to manage their sexual and reproductive health (SRH) with confidence pays long-term dividends in terms of avoiding an unwanted pregnancy, HIV infection or another chronic STI that requires lifelong attention.

SRH is a complex area of healthcare, impacted by socio-cultural taboos that constrain open discussion of sex and by the power of intimate partner relationships to shape health-seeking behaviour. Our health days, activations and CoCurriculum sessions are extremely important because they normalise communication about sex, fill information gaps for many students, and make services easily accessible. More than this, our messaging to students is encouraging, positioning SRH within positive relationships and career prospects. Our GBV Programme contributes to the effectiveness of the SRH Programme, since violence is a major risk factor for HIV.

Students attending CoCurriculum sessions on HIV, TB, STIs and SRH



Students performing self-screening for HIV, TB, STI and SRH risk

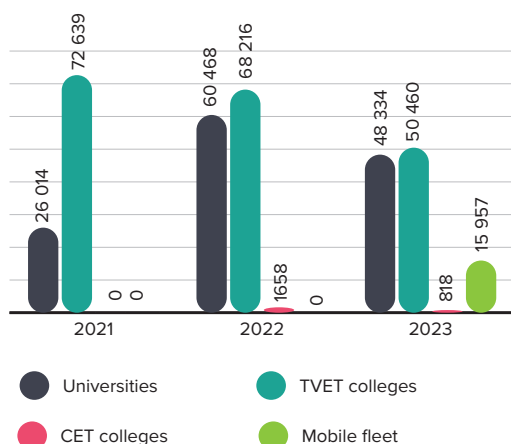


Prevention is HIGHER HEALTH's main objective in respect of HIV, TB, STIs, and unplanned pregnancy. We seek, as far as possible, to provide students access to a choice of prevention methods.

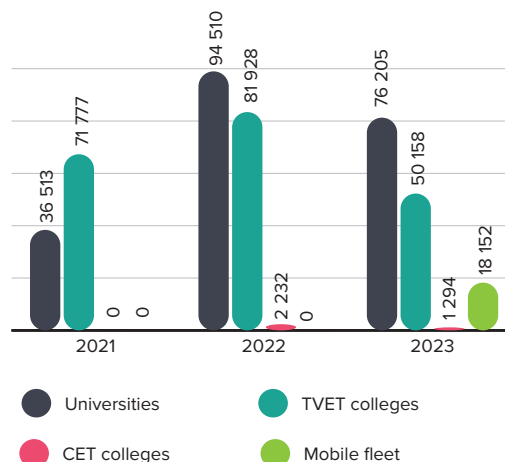
The individual's knowledge of his or her HIV status enables decisions on prevention and treatment, and symptom screening for TB and STIs identifies students who should undergo clinical testing and professional diagnosis. HIGHER HEALTH and our partners provide HIV testing and screening for TB, STIs and various non-communicable diseases (NCDs) during First Things First health days as well as at campus and mobile clinics.

The figures for testing and screening at TVET and CET colleges should be read in conjunction with those recorded for the mobile clinics which service students at these institutions. Overall, uptake of testing and screening was somewhat lower in 2023 than in the previous year.

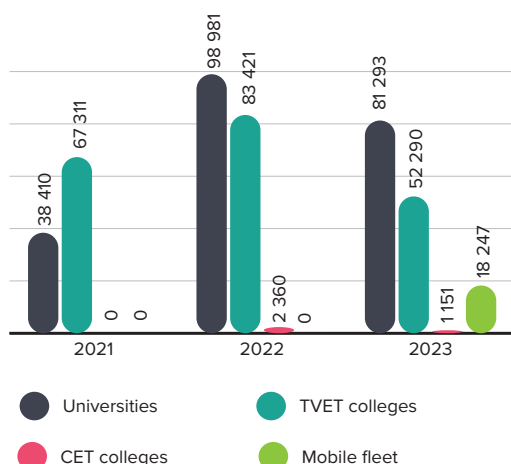
Number of HIV tests performed on campus or at mobile clinics



Number of STI screenings done on campus or at mobile clinics



Number of TB screenings done on campus or at mobile clinics



Outcomes of HIV testing and screening for TB and STIs

	HIV	TB	STIs
Tested/screened	115 569	152 981	152 981
Tested/screened positive	812	2 763	14 198*
Positivity rate	0.7%	1.8%*	9.7%*

* While the HIV test result is generally accurate, screening for TB only identifies probable infection which must be confirmed by a lab test. The STI figure refers to the number treated or referred for treatment.

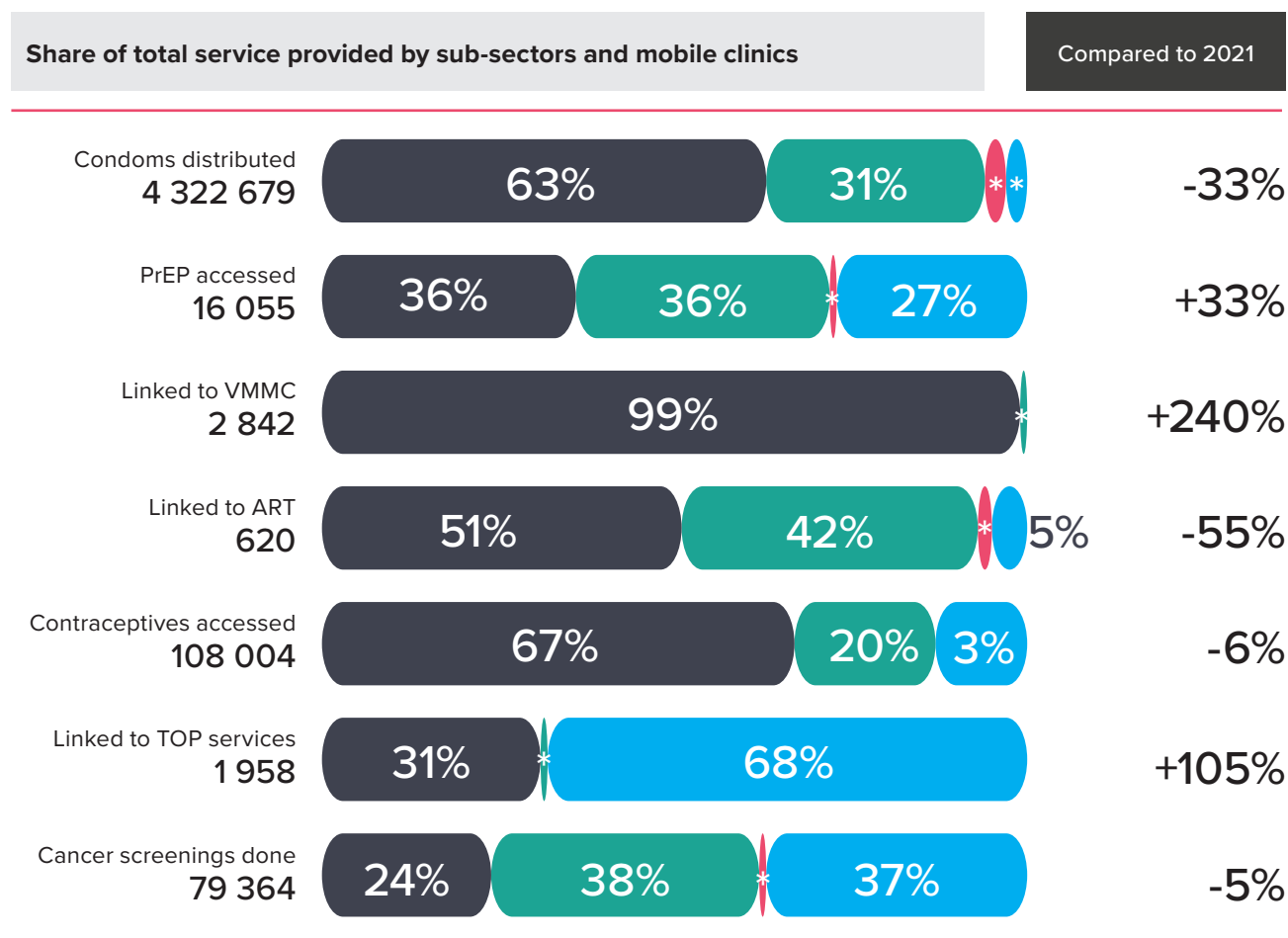
For many years the distribution of free government-issue condoms has been the cornerstone of our SRH and HIV prevention strategy. Condoms remain the only tool for triple protection – against HIV, other STIs and pregnancy – and HIGHER HEALTH continues to advocate strongly for condom use.

Despite this, the volume of condoms distributed on campuses declined 33% from 6.45m in 2022 to 4.32m in 2023. We depend on the Department of Health's national condom programme for our supply and there has been a steady reduction in the distribution of male condoms nationally, from R728m in 2018/19 to R403m in 2022/23, according to the Health Systems Trust. We have made a special effort to secure supplies of female condoms and the number in 2023 was 312 089.



Delivery of Core Programmes *continued*

Access to selected HIV prevention and SRH products and services in 2023



* Percentage of service provision ranges from 1–3%. Anything under 1% is not reflected.

■ Universities ■ TVET colleges ■ CET colleges ■ Mobile clinics



While uptake of the newer HIV prevention option, oral pre-exposure prophylaxis (PrEP), is gaining ground on campuses, the increased uptake does not counterbalance the decline in condom provision. In 2023, campus and mobile clinics referred 16 055 students for oral PrEP, in the form of a daily ARV. This was one-third more than in 2022. PrEP is an important addition to our HIV prevention toolkit as it is gender-neutral and can be used discreetly even in the absence of partner approval. For young women who find they cannot ensure condom use by their partners, oral PrEP is a wonderful alternative.

However, studies have shown that many young people have difficulty maintaining the daily routine of taking oral PrEP. Two long-acting forms of PrEP – a vaginal ring containing the ARV dapivirine and an eight-weekly injection of cabotegravir – have been licensed for use by the South African Health Products Authority (SAHPRA). We look forward to including them as an option for students.

A total of 108 004 contraceptive products were provided or accessed in 2023, slightly fewer than in the previous year. Diversification in the contraceptive methods used by students was evident in 2023, indicating they are being given options that suit their preferences, their bodies and their lifestyles. We trust that this choice of method will encourage greater uptake of contraception as we are a long way from protecting all sexually active women students.

We saw an increase in 2023 in the number of students diagnosed and treated for STIs. This is possibly concerning but it is difficult to distinguish between an actual increase in STIs and improved treatment-seeking. HIGHER HEALTH needs to observe this carefully because some STIs, such as hepatitis C, are not curable and can have serious consequences.

Treatment for HIV and TB is generally not available at campus and mobile clinics and is accessed by referring students to public health clinics or NGOs. Our CHWCs and campus health staff strive to form relationships with managers of these health facilities to ensure referrals are effective. Students whose pregnancy tests are positive are counselled and referred to community facilities for termination of pregnancy or antenatal care. A priority for 2024 is expanding training on the initiation of ART for professional nurses at campus and mobile clinics.

Our SRH services include screening for breast, cervical, prostate and penile cancer. A total of 79 364 screenings were performed, 47% of these for breast cancer and 39% for cervical cancer.

Layering care for better effect

The Adolescent and Young People's (AYP) Programme entered the second year of its renewed funding period in April 2023 and began to gain traction against its performance targets at 25 campuses of 16 TVET colleges.

The programme is funded by the Global Fund to Fight AIDS, TB and STIs and is well-aligned with HIGHER HEALTH's strategic direction. Its objectives are to:

- Reduce new HIV infections among young people.
- Reduce teenage and unwanted pregnancies.
- Reduce GBV.
- Increase the retention of students in PSET.
- Improve economic opportunities for young people.

Students who participate in the Young People's Programme benefit from a combination of health products and interventions. To facilitate this, they have special access – via a PIN – to vending machines supplying free commodities such as male and female condoms, sanitary pads, HIV self-testing kits and pregnancy tests. A total of 37 vending machines have been installed at TVET colleges with connectivity independent of the college's IT infrastructure.

The significant downtime at PSET institutions – with exams and recess periods – presents challenges in meeting targets set by the funder. On average, in 2023/24, participating campuses achieved 61% of the number of HIV tests expected and provided 69% of HIV prevention interventions. There were some outstanding performers that far surpassed targets, but the majority fell short to a greater or lesser extent. Remedial action was initiated during the year, and performance in the last months of the year was much closer to targets.

The AYP grant to HIGHER HEALTH is managed by three Global Fund principal recipients responsible for different provinces: the Networking AIDS Coalition of South Africa (NACOSA), the AIDS Foundation of South Africa (AFSA), and Beyond Zero.

Delivery of Core Programmes *continued*

A watchful eye on NCDs

As part of our holistic approach to health, we encourage students to screen for key non-communicable diseases (NCDs). Not only is diabetes being detected at an earlier age worldwide, but studies have shown that young people in sub-Saharan Africa have a higher rate of elevated blood pressure than their peers in other regions. Most screening is performed on campus, during health and wellness days or at fixed clinics. The HIGHER HEALTH mobile fleet performs about 20% of screenings.



Gender-Based Violence Programme

Of all HIGHER HEALTH's programmes, the Gender-Based Violence Programme places most emphasis on social and structural interventions. Much of our work involves building the policy infrastructure needed to support a gender-inclusive campus environment and promote the norm of zero tolerance of GBV. We invest time in working with a range of campus managers and staff members to ensure their ownership of these policies and their grasp of the guidelines and protocols which serve as implementing tools.

In addition, we apply the standard HIGHER HEALTH Model of knowledge transfer, practice-based learning and access to services to the area of GBV in an effort to prevent such violence among students, intervene early, and provide appropriate care to those who experience it.

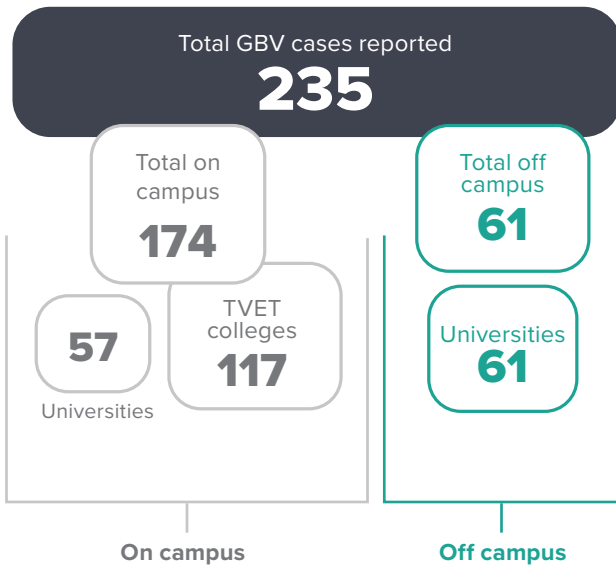
In August 2023 HIGHER HEALTH, in partnership with the DHET and UNESCO, convened a PSET sector summit where delegates embraced the UNESCO initiative, Transforming MENTalities (see box on page 28). The summit was followed by our CEO's attendance of two key UNESCO meetings in January and March 2024 and a visit to our office by a UNESCO team from Paris led by Mr Borhene Chakroun, Director for Policies and Lifelong Learning Systems.

The work we have done over the past five years to develop PSET sector policies and processes on gender equity and GBV forms a solid foundation for the normative change that the Transforming MENTalities approach envisages. Going forward we intend an increased focus on men students and the cultural discourse on gender.

Reports of GBV in the sector

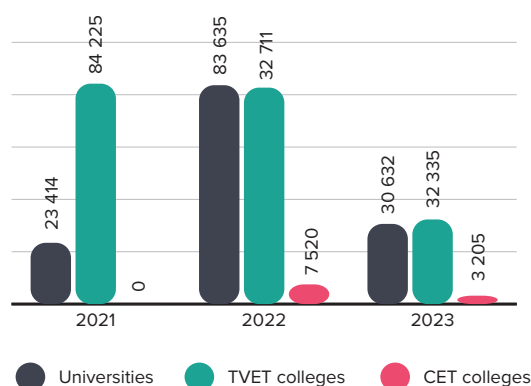
Despite efforts across the sector to prevent GBV, in 2023 a total of 235 students reported they had been subjected to GBV. This was considerably lower than the previous year, when 385 cases were reported. About equal numbers of university and TVET college students were affected, and three out of four reports concerned on-campus GBV. However, while university students reported GBV occurring both on and off campus, reports by TVET college students related exclusively to campus violence.

Summary of GBV cases reported by students 2023



Tragically, the PSET sector still loses a small number of students to femicide. These events reverberate across the affected campuses and HIGHER HEALTH offers significant assistance to institutional management in responding to these crises.

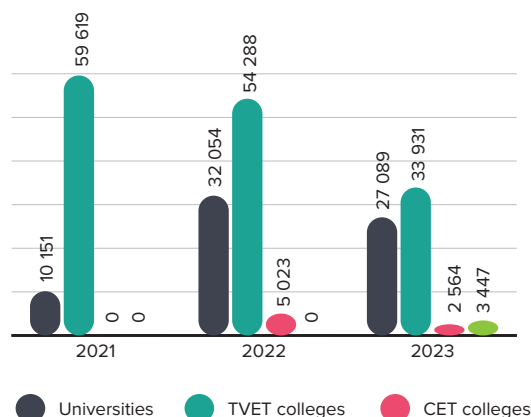
Students participating in CoCurriculum sessions on GBV



On average, 13% of students performing the self-assessment were considered at high risk of GBV.

A total of 4 259 students were referred for GBV counselling, compared to 5 308 in 2022. The majority of these (68%) were university students. The aim of counselling for students at risk is to prevent them experiencing violence or, if they have already been exposed, to deal with the trauma and prevent continued abuse.

Students performing self-assessment of GBV risk



Technical support and training

The development of policies, guidelines and protocols on GBV for the sector is an ongoing process. After the DHET's adoption of the PSET Framework on GBV in 2020, HIGHER HEALTH began to craft policies and broad guidelines, and each year we fill in the detail through procedural guidelines, protocols and other implementation tools.

The DHET's endorsement of these instruments encourages institutions to adopt them. We greatly appreciated Deputy Minister Manamela's formal launch, in May 2023, of a cluster of guidelines and protocols that had been finalised in the previous year.

The programme benefits from the guidance of the GBV Technical Task Team, a panel of experts who keep our staff abreast of new evidence and best practices and contribute to our policy and implementation documents. In addition, in 2023 we sought the advice of the National Prosecuting Authority (NPA) to ensure that the protocols in development were in accordance with relevant legislation. We are keen to expand this collaboration with the NPA.

Since adopting GBV as a key focus area several years ago, HIGHER HEALTH has provided training on guidelines and protocols to about 8 900 managers, staff members and student leaders at institutions. In 2023, 424 staff members from across the sector participated in webinars on GBV protocols. Our aim of transforming campuses into safe zones for students rests on the commitment of many role-players, including security staff, accommodation managers, human resources practitioners and student council members.



Delivery of Core Programmes *continued*



A hearts and minds approach to eliminating GBV

At a summit convened in August 2023, the PSET sector signaled its support for the international Transforming MENTALITIES initiative which asserts that we must change the way that men in our societies think about gender if we want to achieve a more equal world, free of violence against girls and women.

Transforming MENTALITIES was launched in 2015 in Costa Rica and is coordinated by UNESCO. As its name suggests, it promotes the engagement of men as a way of eliminating harmful gender norms that remain widespread in many countries.

The South African PSET sector summit on Transforming MENTALITIES was organised by HIGHER HEALTH, the DHET and UNESCO and attracted nearly 1 000 participants.

The keynote address was delivered by Minister of Higher Education, Science and Innovation Dr Blade Nzimande, who said: “Gender inequality is not a woman’s issue. It is a human rights issue that affects everyone in society. . . . Conventionally, issues about gender equality have mainly been placed in the public arena by women. However, it is difficult to reform social structures towards equality without a broad social consensus between men and women.”

The summit declaration took the form of a pledge by participants to:

- Challenge harmful gender norms and attitudes.
- Embrace responsible and active fatherhood and caregiving.
- Understand and practice consent in all sexual engagements.
- Strive to create educational spaces that are nurturing and respectful of every student.
- Collaborate with organisations, activists and movements dedicated to gender equality.

Evidence of the need to reshape collective thinking is presented in the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) Gender Social Norms Index for 2023. This survey of attitudes in 80 countries found that 25% of people believe it is justified for a man to beat his wife.

Gender biases, held by both men and women, reflect in many ways, says the UNDP, including severe under-representation of women in political and business leadership and unequal pay. Data show that attitudes rather than aptitude hold women back. “Even in 59 countries where women are more educated than men, the average gender income gap remains a staggering 39% in favour of men,” the UNDP remarked.

The index found gender biases were most widespread in relation to physical integrity, where 75% of respondents indicated biases against women that can be linked to intimate partner violence and impact on women’s reproductive rights.

Mental Health Programme

HIGHER HEALTH's Mental Health Programme continued to create awareness of mental health, combat stigma related to this aspect of health, and expand counselling and other care available to affected students.

The particular need to improve access to mental health care was highlighted in 2022 by the publication of a survey of 29 000 South African university students. This found nearly one in five students would benefit from psychosocial support and small sub-group required specialised clinical care – but 70% of these individuals were not getting the assistance they needed (Source: USAf/SAMRC survey within WHO World Mental Health International College Student Initiative).

In 2023, HIGHER HEALTH added registered counsellors to its provincial healthcare teams and, in some instances, stationed them at institutions. All counsellors have at least an undergraduate degree in psychology, usually with an additional relevant qualification – in some cases a master's degree in psychology.

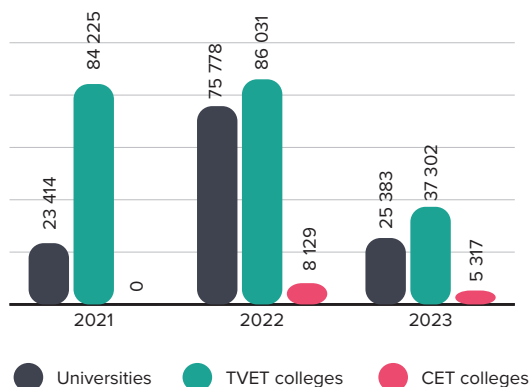
Creating awareness and combating stigma

Through health days and CoCurriculum sessions we build understanding of mental health, combat stigma and convey the message that help is available both for mental disorders and short-term emotional crises. In 2023, 68 002 students participated in relevant CoCurriculum sessions.

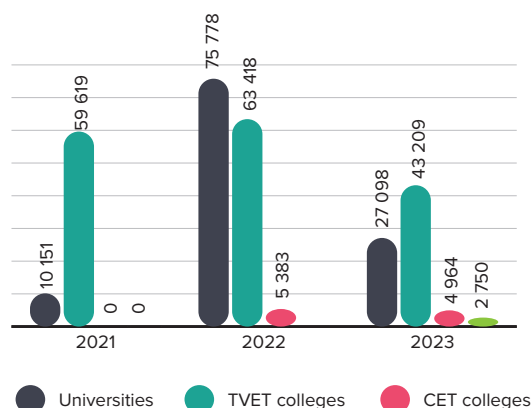
Self-identification of mental vulnerability

Because the signs of common mental disorders, such as anxiety and depression, are not widely recognised, the HIGHER HEALTH screening tool for mental health is particularly useful. A total of 78 021 students performed the mental health self-assessment and, sector-wide, 6% were considered at high risk of a mental health disorder. The majority were referred for psychosocial assistance.

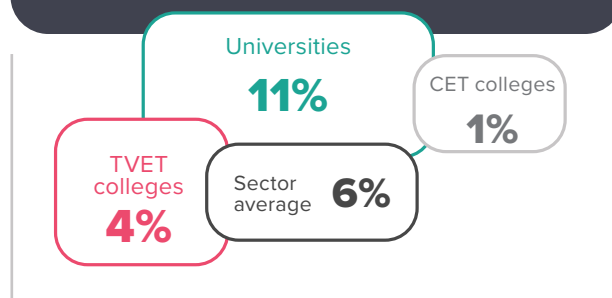
Students attending CoCurriculum sessions on mental health



Students performing self-assessment of mental health risk



Percentage of screened students at high risk of mental disorder



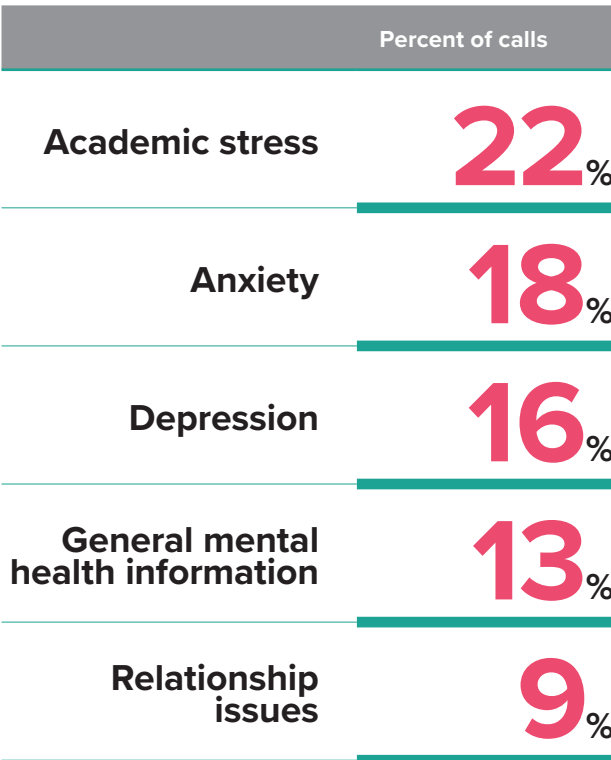
Linkage to services

Psychosocial services for the PSET sector continued to be provided through:

- The 24-hour crisis helpline, run by HIGHER HEALTH and the South African Depression and Anxiety Group, which offers immediate psychosocial support to callers and refers them to other services where more extended care is required. The Helpline dealt with 12 550 calls and mobile messages, slightly more than in the previous year.
- On-campus student counselling units and clinics, which are generally available at universities and some larger TVET colleges, plus our mobile clinics. In 2023, the total number of on-campus interventions was 7 122.
- Our clinical psychologists and registered counsellors, who provide individual and group therapy within a time-limited model of up to six sessions per person. In 2023, these sessions increased to 13 821 from 11 185 the previous year.

Delivery of Core Programmes *continued*

Top reasons for students seeking mental health services



Reasons for the remaining 22% included general stress, abuse and trauma, suicidal thoughts, bereavement and family issues.

Vulnerable Populations Programme

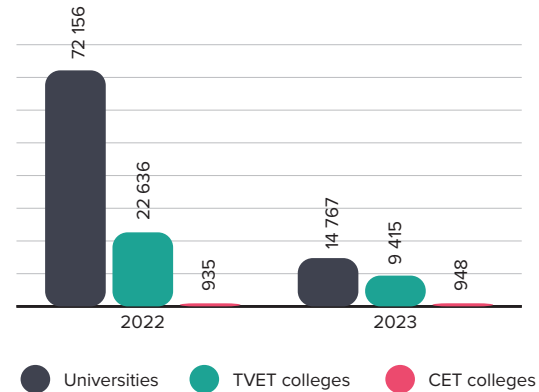
HIGHER HEALTH recognises that there are groups of students whose health and wellbeing may be compromised because they are marginalised by prejudice and other factors in the campus environment. They also have some unique health needs and campus service providers need to understand and be responsive to these.

We have focused over the years on LGBTQI students, those with disabilities, and those with problematic alcohol and drug habits.

Although these are distinct groups requiring different solutions, they share the experience of stigma and exclusion which HIGHER HEALTH seeks to address by sensitisation and educational interventions directed at the broader campus community. The vehicles for these are the CoCurriculum, the Future Beats radio programme and a range of peer education activities.

We also strive to enable healthcare workers in campus and mobile clinics to offer services that cater to the unique healthcare needs of LGBTQI students, substance users, and students with disabilities. Through our peer educator network, we have created support groups on some campuses to empower students belonging to vulnerable groups.

Students attending CoCurriculum sessions on gender, disability and substance use



Civic and Health Peer Education Programme

Within nine months of Minister Nzimande's official launch of our Civic and Health Peer Education Programme in July 2023, a total of 5 467 students and staff had signed onto the digital platform to participate in the pilot run of the programme.

The skills programme is accredited by the Quality Council for Trades and Occupations (QCTO) and applies the principles of active citizenship to the field of health promotion. Candidates who successfully complete all modules – which have both a theoretical and a practical requirement – achieve a recognised NQF level 5 skills certificate.

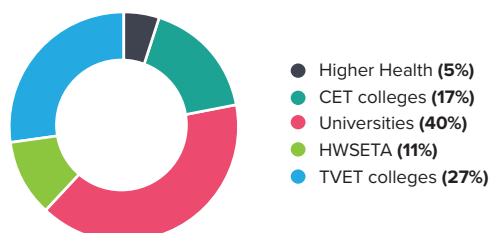
In last year's report, we described how HIGHER HEALTH designed the programme content in partnership with the Health and Welfare Sector Education and Training Authority (HWSETA) and steered it through the QCTO accreditation process. It is managed and delivered by the HIGHER HEALTH Academy accommodated at head office.

In the past year:

- HIGHER HEALTH, the QCTO and HWSETA formalised their collaboration in a memorandum of understanding.
- HIGHER HEALTH was accredited as a skills development provider or academy by the QCTO.
- The National Skills Fund (NSF) committed substantial funding to the programme.
- The HWSETA provided bursaries for 5 000 participants in the programme and the Education, Training and Development Practices (EDTP) SETA pledged a further 1 350 bursaries.
- A partnership was formed with educational technology specialists Anthology and OneConnect and this underpins the development of the Microsoft-based digital platform.

In May 2023 we commenced a pre-pilot project during which 200 of our staff registered for the programme. The University of Johannesburg (UJ) provided digital hosting for this phase.

Distribution of pilot participants



This process of appointing dedicated inhouse capacity to manage the digital platform commenced during the year.

Participants in the pilot project, which kicked off in September 2023, were assigned to different “classes” – a university cohort, TVET college cohort, CET college cohort, HWSETA cohort and HIGHER HEALTH cohort. They underwent induction to assist them to use the software and manage their learning.

Early insights

As part of the pilot, we conducted 16 focus groups to gain insight into the initial experiences of programme participants. In general participants considered the curriculum relevant, interesting and personally empowering (see box on page 32). However, many experienced difficulty finding time to complete the required work.

In addition, HIGHER HEALTH has come to realise:

- The digital divide is real and deep. A significant number of participants lacked access to laptops or personal computers and connectivity. Consequently, they were not confident tech users and found the online environment quite stressful.

- A high proportion of students have difficulty using the Blackboard platform. Problems range from initial registration to inability to access test grades.
- Online engagement does not come naturally to all. Even participants proficient in the use of digital tools did not interact as fully as desired. HIGHER HEALTH ran a digital campaign to encourage more participative learning.
- There is an unmet need for psychosocial support. The curriculum uncovered vulnerabilities among participants and a need to refer them to HIGHER HEALTH or campus services.

Expanding the modules

As HIGHER HEALTH presented the Civic and Health Peer Education Programme to various stakeholders, we received requests to expand the curriculum by adding modules on financial literacy and climate change. Cabinet subsequently requested content on the history of our democracy be added to the civics module.

The eight-module version has been submitted to the CTPO for accreditation and will be known as the Civic and Soft Skills Programme.

Ripples of interest

No matter how innovative a capacity development programme is, it seldom attracts a loud fanfare and requires dedicated marketing. Our CEO and Minister Nzimande have led the way.

- In government, presentations on the programme were made to cabinet by the Director-General in DHET and to top structures of the DHET.
- Prof Ahluwalia held discussions about the programme with UNESCO, as detailed in the CEO’s Overview in this report.

Delivery of Core Programmes *continued*

VOICES FROM THE PILOT PHASE



Focus groups in the first quarter of 2024 gave a glimpse of participants' reactions to the course content.

'I teach life orientation and the course covers relevant information based on reality – it is what happens in life . . . You can apply the knowledge and skills in your own life. I am even encouraging others to apply for and do this course.'



'I liked the disability module the most because it includes sign language and I want to learn sign language.'



'I always wanted to be a public speaker but . . . I used to get cold feet. I realise I was thinking about myself. I also realise I must train myself and speak to others more.'



'I realised that . . . things have been holding me back due to my environment where certain things are not allowed or frowned upon. For example, gender diversity and LGBTI issues . . . Now I can allow myself to make it happen at some stage and be myself.'



'We didn't know that elections are important. We just thought it was a thing to get money and young people are not interested. But now I know why we need elections.'



'(I learnt) about mental health – what causes stress. I also learnt I must share my feelings and not just keep them inside. I realised the mind is an important asset.'

Universities Programme

In 2023 we saw encouraging consolidation of the structures through which HIGHER HEALTH realises its partnership with universities. At individual universities, many institutional health and wellness committees functioned at a higher level and across the sub-sector specialised forums appeared revitalised.

HIGHER HEALTH assists universities to build health and wellness programmes by providing modest but important financial resources, dedicated technical support, and training of staff and peer educators. We also facilitate the lateral sharing of knowledge and experience by convening forums of various categories of campus staff.

Financial support to universities

HIGHER HEALTH's grants to universities are intended to support implementation of our model for the promotion of student health and wellness. While universities exercise significant choice in how to implement the model, each institution is required to meet key performance targets and report regularly on progress.

May 2023 saw the closure of a two-year cycle of grant funding and the next grant period commenced in June. All 26 public universities were awarded grants in this round of funding and the total grant allocation for 2023/25 was R14.2 million, an increase of 30% on the amount of R10.96 million allocated in 2021. Individual grants varied from R400 000 to R650 000. The amount was informed by a general principle of equity combined with the capacity of the institution to utilise the full amount.

The table below summarises reported performance against targets for the previous grant and amounts allocated in June 2023. In several cases, figures suggesting low performance are misleading as the problem was actually inadequate reporting of activity. Some universities experienced difficulties enabling students to complete risk assessments and this affected their overall score.

Performance against previous grant targets and allocations for 2023/24

University	Achievement of targets 2021/22 – 2022/23 grant cycle	Amount allocated for 2023/25
Cape Peninsula University of Technology (CPUT)	68%	R600 000
Central University of Technology (CUT)	45%	R500 000
Durban University of Technology (DUT)	55%	R650 000
Mangosuthu University of Technology (MUT)	2%	R400 000
Nelson Mandela University (NMU)	16%	R500 000
North West University (NWU)	9%	R500 000
Rhodes University (RU)	51%	R500 000
Sefako Makgatho Health Sciences University (SMU)	N/A	R400 000
Sol Plaatje University (SPU)	92%	R400 000
Stellenbosch University (SU)	104%	R650 000
Tshwane University of Technology (TUT)	21%	R600 000
University of Cape Town (UCT)	5%	R650 000
University of Fort Hare (UFH)	78%	R600 000
University of the Free State (UFS)	103%	R650 000
University of Johannesburg (UJ)	19%	R600 000
University of KwaZulu-Natal (UKZN)	128%	R650 000
University of Limpopo (UL)	286%	R650 000
University of Mpumalanga (UMP)	483%	R400 000
University of Pretoria (UP)	40%	R450 000
University of South Africa (Unisa)	N/A	R600 000
University of Venda (Univen)	119%	R650 000
University of Zululand (Unizulu)	41%	R500 000
University of the Western Cape (UWC)	23%	R500 000
University of the Witwatersrand (Wits)	104%	R600 000
Vaal University of Technology (VUT)	190%	R550 000
Walter Sisulu University (WSU)	171%	R450 000
Total		R14 200 000

Delivery of Core Programmes *continued*

HIGHER HEALTH took action in three key areas to assist universities achieve the targets set:

- We supported the renewal and functioning of institutional health and wellness committees which guide and oversee the implementation of campus health and wellness programmes and serve as our principal point of contact. Most universities reviewed the composition and functioning of these structures during the course of the year.
- We encouraged universities to cast their nets wider when recruiting peer educators and to incorporate volunteers from other student support structures, such as counselling units, gender units and transformation units. We have a grant-linked target for the number of peer educators recruited, trained and deployed, ranging from 100 to 300 per university. Meeting this target lays the foundation for achievement of other standards.
- We required that some grant funding be allocated to the production of co-branded educational materials and campaign items in order to reach more students and increase HIGHER HEALTH's visibility on campuses.

Technical support and training

Apart from the development of national policies, guidelines and protocols related to our focus areas, HIGHER HEALTH provides training on these to various categories of campus management and staff, and student leadership. We also provide training to enable peer educators at universities to deliver modules of the CoCurriculum to their fellow students. In the past this has involved a train-the-trainer model, but in 2023 HIGHER HEALTH staff became more involved in providing direct training to peer educators, offering this service at eight institutions.

Conferences of various occupational groups within the PSET sector serve as invaluable opportunities for HIGHER HEALTH to share information and practice-based insights. For example, we participated in the conferences of the SA Association for Counselling and Development in Higher Education (SAACHDE), the Campus Protection Society of Southern Africa (CAMPROSA), and the Association of College and University Housing Officers International – Southern African Chapter (ACUHOI-SAC), and the roundtable of the SA Association of Senior Student Affairs Professionals.

GBV is a particularly complex area of work that demands a high level of technical support. During the year, we conducted a GBV workshop with the South African Union of Students (SAUS), led the technical input from the higher education sector at the workshop to integrate the National Strategic Plan on GBV into government department plans, and co-hosted two GBV assemblies at UCT and NWU with the Deputy Minister of Higher Education, Mr Buti Manamela.

Enhancing collaboration

Most universities have well-established student health clinics that provide some of the HIV, TB and SRH services that are essential to the HIGHER HEALTH Model. However, support from the public health sector in the form of diagnostics and other healthcare supplies is critical to the delivery of such services. HIGHER HEALTH facilitates this partnership between health authorities and universities through multiple meetings every year. In 2023, the focus of these engagements was combining forces to scale up the provision of ART and PrEP on campuses and getting campus clinics registered as medicine pick-up points for students with chronic conditions who are being treated at public health clinics.

Universities hosted significant health events including the World TB Day event (NWU and Orbit TVET College in partnership with the SA National AIDS Council [SANAC]), a Ministerial event at SPU, and the launch of the ASSIST pilot project to combat alcohol, tobacco and substance use (UCT and the Department of Social Development [DSD]).

TVET and CET College Programme

While HIGHER HEALTH works mainly behind the scenes in the university sub-sector, in the TVET and CET sub-sectors our partnership with colleges is upfront and close to the coal face of programme delivery. The relationship between CHWCs seconded to colleges from our provincial offices and key college staff is critical to delivery of health days and the CoCurriculum, and the recruitment, training and mentoring of peer educators.

This operational partnership is strengthened by HIGHER HEALTH's fleet of mobile clinics that provide dedicated health and psychosocial services to TVET colleges on a roster basis

Because many TVET college campuses are smaller and draw their students from the local area, they are more embedded in their communities and organisations in the community are frequently mobilised to enrich campus health and wellness activities. The same is true of CET learning centres.

Sustaining our CHWC corps

Nationally, HIGHER HEALTH has 45 positions for CHWCs in the TVET sub-sector and 27 in the CET sub-sector. Our TVET and CET College Programme depends critically on ensuring that:

- All CHWC positions are filled with qualified and highly motivated young people.
- New recruits receive comprehensive training in the HIGHER HEALTH Model and other necessary skills.
- Refresher training is offered regularly to CHWCs as our interventions evolve.
- CHWCs have strong provincial office supervision and support. Their jobs are complex and taxing, and they need the affirmation and guidance of experienced managers.

As explained earlier, the transition between grants led to a substantial number of CHCW posts becoming vacant at the end of 2023.

Capacity building at college level

Equally important to CHWCs are the college staff members who help to deliver HIGHER HEALTH programmes and the peer educators who volunteer each year to mobilise fellow students and raise awareness of health issues. Educating staff members and peer educators about our priority health areas and building skills for programme delivery takes place every year, as new individuals enter the system.

In the 2023 academic year, a total of 1 353 peer educators from TVET colleges and 28 from CET centres attended formal training sessions. These deliver accurate information about relevant health areas – for example, HIV, TB, contraception and mental health, build participants' communication skills and ability to provide support to others, and develop a human rights-based value framework.

Capacity-building training for CET centre managers and lecturers included training in basic counselling.



Health care on the move

In 2023, as in the previous year, HIGHER HEALTH deployed 10 mobile clinics to TVET colleges that lack fixed clinics. Unfortunately, we have not been able to expand the fleet and continue to prioritise large colleges so that we reach the maximum number of students possible.

Each mobile clinic is staffed by a professional nurse and an enrolled nurse who provide HIV testing, contraception, screening and treatment for STIs, screening for TB, various cancers and mental disorders, serve as collection points for chronic medication, and refer patients to public health clinics or to non-profit partners for clinical management.

Our M&E framework now allows for separate recording of mobile clinic outputs and the list below is a sample of their activity.

- Testing and screening: HIV tests – 15 957; TB screenings – 18 247; STI screenings – 18 152; NCD screenings – 35 034; cancer screenings – 29 215.
- HIV and SRH services: contraceptives provided – 14 368; PrEP referrals – 4 444; pregnancy tests – 2 643; referral for pregnancy termination – 1 340.
- Mental health and GBV: risk assessment GBV – 3 447; risk assessment mental health – 2 750.

The Department of Health coordinated training on HIV testing for five of our professional nurses who will serve as trainers for other nurses in the sector and CHWCs. This will help improve the quality of our HIV counselling and testing, increase access to testing, and create better linkage to ART and PrEP initiation.

Delivery of Core Programmes *continued*

Meet some of our registered counsellors



CEBISILE KUBHEKA holds a Master of Social Science in counselling psychology from UKZN. After completing her internship at Helen Joseph Hospital in Johannesburg, she worked for the Department of Basic Education as a school-based psychologist, the DHET as a university student psychologist, and the South African Medical Research Council (SAMRC). She is licensed as a counselling psychologist by the Health Professions Council of SA (HPCSA) and works for HIGHER HEALTH in Limpopo and Mpumalanga.

SIPHESIHLE SANDILE DLAMINI holds a master's degree in counselling psychology from UKZN and heads HIGHER HEALTH's psychosocial team. He has practised in Johannesburg at Helen Joseph Hospital, the Child and Family Centre, Alexandra High School and Houghton House rehabilitation centre. He is registered with the HPCSA as a counselling psychologist and is a member of the Psychological Society of SA (PsySSA).



KEFENTSE SETHOBA undertook a human and societal dynamics degree at UFS and completed her community service learning at Kruitberg Primary School, Bloemfontein. To gain work experience, she volunteered as a clerk at the South African Social Security Agency (SASSA), went on to become a career development intern at Goldfields TVET College and in 2019 joined HIGHER HEALTH as a CHWC. She rejoined us in 2024 as a counsellor registered with the Association for Supportive Counsellors and Holistic Practitioners.

Community partners

Public health clinics, local offices of provincial departments of social development (DSDs), and various NGOs play an important part in enhancing both the prevention and treatment aspects of the HIGHER HEALTH programme.

Clinics are widely available and we refer students for care when their colleges are not served by our mobile units or when they need care beyond the scope of services offered by our clinics. Wherever possible, HIGHER HEALTH concludes service level agreements with the district or provincial health authority to formalise the referral arrangement. Elsewhere referrals are underpinned by building relationships with clinic managers and staff.

Our NGO partners are invested in work similar to our own. Several have been funded by the Global Fund or the US President's Emergency Plan for AIDS Response (PEPFAR) to provide HIV programmes for young people in particular districts. Others work in the areas of GBV prevention, alcohol harm reduction, LGBTQI rights, mental health, and youth development. They frequently collaborate with HIGHER HEALTH to provide services to students. In a few instances, private companies have partnered with HIGHER HEALTH – for instance, financial institutions have occasionally offered financial literacy sessions.

Coordination and networking

In each province, HIGHER HEALTH organises meetings of key role-players in the provision of services to TVET colleges and CET centres. The objective is to review our collective performance, identify and propose solutions to challenges encountered, and learn from each other's experiences. In 2023, we were able to convene seven provincial meetings which were attended by a total of 461 representatives.

Communication and Mass Media Programme

HIGHER HEALTH's engagement with the mass media, its use of social media platforms, and its creation of printed materials for sector-wide distribution serve to enhance our work in pursuit of student health and wellbeing.

In 2023, we made strides in the digital and social media space by refreshing our website and using social media more proactively to talk about our work and our people.

We built on the HIGHER HEALTH tradition of strong face-to-face communication by our provincial managers participating in 2024 induction week activities at several universities and colleges.

Participating in national discourse

HIGHER HEALTH interacts with major broadcast, print and digital media whenever we have something to contribute to the national dialogue on the health of students and other young people. Typically, these opportunities arise when topics such as HIV, young women's rights, student mental health and GBV are in the spotlight. Prof Ahluwalia is the organisation's main spokesperson and his approach is invariably to try and educate the public about the issues and indicate the kinds of help that are available to young people.

The standout media event was the Transforming MENTalities Summit held in August 2023, which featured:

- A live radio broadcast from the venue on SAfm, including interviews with Ministers Nzimande and Dlamini-Zuma and HIGHER HEALTH's CEO.
- Coverage by television channels such as Newzroom Afrika, SABC News and eNCA.
- Print and digital media articles in titles reaching diverse regions and readers.

Enabling student engagement

We also enlist the media to drive health-seeking behaviours and health living among students. The best example of this is our Future Beats partnership with selected campus and community radio stations. HIGHER HEALTH makes a modest grant to each participating station and provides station managers and presenters with training on our priority health areas as well as the goals we are seeking to achieve.

The stations produce regular radio shows on health topics of interest to HIGHER HEALTH, using their creativity and connection with their audiences to elicit interest in the subject. We encourage programme formats that allow students to participate and debate the topics because there is evidence that behaviour change requires engagement with ideas, rather than mere exposure to them.

In 2023, Future Beats had 22 participating stations with a combined listenership of just over one million and social media reach of close to 600 000 people.

Some community stations went off air during the year because they failed to renew their licences with the Independent Broadcasting Authority of South Africa (ICASA). We have not had this situation previously and it indicates we need to establish the regulatory compliance of radio stations each year before selecting them for Future Beats.

Delivery of Core Programmes *continued*

HIGHER HEALTH provides all stations with a schedule of topics and themes that are linked to the national health calendar and events in the academic year.

Campus and community radio stations participating in Future Beats in 2023

Station	Type of station	Listeners	Social media reach	Grant amount
Eastern Cape				
Forte FM	Campus	7 000	13 173	50 000
Unitra FM	Community	250 000	28 389	36 000
Madibaz FM	Campus	15 000	19 956	40 000
Mdantsane FM	Community	115 000	20 469	40 000
Alfred Nzo	Community	138 000	4 559	40 000
Free State				
CUT FM	Campus	38 000	62 735	30 000
Motheo FM	Community	116 000	–	45 000
QwaQwa FM	Community	83 000	22 334	45 000
Gauteng				
VOW FM	Campus	13 000	48 376	80 000
UNISA Radio	Campus	15 000	48 973	30 000
Tshwane Radio	Campus	38 000	35 865	45 000
KwaZulu-Natal				
Durban Youth Radio	Community	256 000	21 686	60 000
Maputaland Radio	Community	165 000	65 394	65 000
Zululand FM	Community	37 000	4 183	35 000
Imvula FM	Commercial	–	–	15 000
Limpopo				
Univen Radio	Campus	80 000	22 639	20 000
Radio Turf	Campus	64 000	31 297	25 000
Mpumalanga				
Emalahleni FM	Community	73 000	40 147	34 000
Barberton Radio	Community	55 000	242	35 000
North West				
Mahikeng FM	Community	124 000	55 362	25 000
Western Cape				
Eden FM	Community	108 000	25 054	34 408
UCT FM	Campus	12 000	23 000	35 000
Total		1 040 000	593 833	R864 408

Keeping in touch with our stakeholders

HIGHER HEALTH maintains a presence on **X** (formerly Twitter), Facebook, LinkedIn and YouTube, all of which can be used in versatile ways. To some extent, these serve as tools for health awareness campaigns. But their more significant contribution is building cohesion within the HIGHER HEALTH community by sharing real-time information on significant developments at head office and various institutions.

On average, our social media followers increased by 20% during the year.

- On Facebook, which has a broad appeal to diverse audiences, HIGHER HEALTH has 14 516 followers.
- On LinkedIn we have 3 123 followers, mainly from the professional community.

- On **X**, we have attracted 2 530 followers who value timely updates and concise information.

In 2023 we redesigned our website which remains an important resource for stakeholders and members of the public. We also introduced new digital and social offerings:

- A digital newsletter.
- #FridayFaces campaign, designed to humanise the HIGHER HEALTH brand by introducing people working behind the scenes in head office, the regions and provinces.

Branding and information materials

HIGHER HEALTH distributes branding materials to create visibility during health days on campuses and to mark special events in the life of our organisation.

We also produce posters and pamphlets for distribution to campuses to raise awareness of health and wellness issues, provide sound information, and direct students to services. Our combined print-run of 3 550 posters and 80 000 leaflets is modest given the size of the student population. To boost availability, we have expressly required that universities in future spend a portion of their HIGHER HEALTH grants on promotional and educational materials.

Creating interfaces

HIGHER HEALTH's rapid expansion in the last few years has rested largely on a widening circle of partners and

other role-players. HIGHER HEALTH strives to share important milestones with our stakeholders through national events such as the launch of the Civic and Health Peer Education Programme and the Transforming MENTALities Summit.

We are fortunate that both Minister Nzimande and Deputy Minister Manamela are strongly invested in the cause of student health and wellness and regularly participate in our national and campus-based activities. Having Deputy Minister Manamela heading up the Mandela-Sobukwe Leadership Retreat for peer educators has made it a highlight of our events calendar.

Prof Ahluwalia's schedule attempts to balance visits and participation in events at the operational level with national and international engagements designed to form new relationships and sustain a dynamic organisation.



Delivery of Core Programmes *continued*

A selection of significant events and meetings involving the CEO appears below.

CEO's participation on selected public platforms

April 2023	Participated in national STI Week event at SPU, hosted by Deputy Minister of Health Sibongiseni Dlomo. Attended a conference on Ending Sex for Education, Fees, Grades and First Jobs held at Wilton Park in the UK.
May 2023	Contributed to the 15th BRICS Academic Forum on transforming education and skills development to meet future needs. Participated in the National Conference for Student Leadership in TVET Colleges.
June 2023	Hosted a session at the 11th SA AIDS Conference.
July 2023	Hosted the launch of the Civic and Health Peer Education Programme at Tshwane North TVET College with Minister Nzimande delivering the keynote address.
August 2023	Hosted the Transforming MENTalities Summit in Ekurhuleni. Speakers included Minister Nzimande, Minister in the Presidency for Women, Children and Persons with Disabilities Dr Nkosazana Dlamini-Zuma and UNESCO Assistant Director-General for Social and Human Sciences Gabriela Ramos.
September 2023	Addressed UCT's GBV and Femicide Assembly, which was also addressed by Deputy Minister Manamela.
October 2023	Addressed Mask Unity Men's Conference, hosted by UFS and attended by CUT and SP. Attended the conference of the Southern Chapters of the Association of College and University Housing Officers in Cape Town. Made a presentation on the Civic and Health Peer Education Programme to SAPCO national executive.
November 2023	Participated in a panel discussion at the conference of the Feminist Network for Gender Transformation in Istanbul, convened by three United Nations agencies. Attended Universities UK conference on mental health and wellbeing, London. Co-hosted with Deputy Minister Manamela the GBV assembly at NWU's Potchefstroom campus. Attended Deputy Minister Manamela's event build-up event for World AIDS Day, held in partnership with the SANAC at Umfolozi TVET College.
December 2023	Attended national World AIDS Day commemoration led by Deputy President Paul Mashatile and Minister of Health Dr Joe Phaahla in Ilembé, KwaZulu-Natal.
February 2024	Addressed the Mandela-Sobukwe Leadership Retreat 2024 in Cape Town which was led by Deputy Minister Manamela and attended by 130 selected peer educators.



SECTION 4

MANAGEMENT REPORT

Management Report

Human Resources

HIGHER HEALTH's staff complement in 2023/24 was about equal in size to the previous year. At the end of March 2024, it stood at 170, slightly lower than at the previous financial year-end.

Major priorities in the establishment of new posts were strengthening senior management, expanding our capacity to offer psychosocial care, and gearing up systems to deliver the Civic and Health Peer Education Programme.

- In terms of senior management, HIGHER HEALTH appointed leads for monitoring and evaluation, governance and compliance, and communications.
- Counselling services for the TVET and CET sub-sectors were strengthened by employing seven registered counsellors, all with degrees in psychology, who were inserted into the healthcare teams operating from our provincial offices and selected institutions.
- The foundation of the dedicated team for the Civic and Soft Skills Programme was laid with the appointment of four staffers to set up the system for the conduct of the pilot project. Ultimately this team will expand to 20 staff members with varied skills and be headed by a Director for E-Learning and Technology.

In the last report we mentioned our aim of acquiring a payroll system with enhanced functionality. This was achieved during the year and the new system was due to go live on 1 April 2024.

We also created an employment equity committee, as planned, and this is functioning smoothly.

There are inherent problems in managing human resources where most employees are on fixed-term contracts linked to grant funding. Retention becomes more difficult as staff members may be tempted to leave for better job security. We have stabilised key posts by ensuring that they are not tied to a single grant. Unfortunately, we cannot expand this to the entire staff complement and we occasionally let staff go where there are gaps between the end of a grant cycle and the start of another. At the end of 2023, we lost 19 CHWCs who had been employed through grants to provide time-limited work experience for young people.

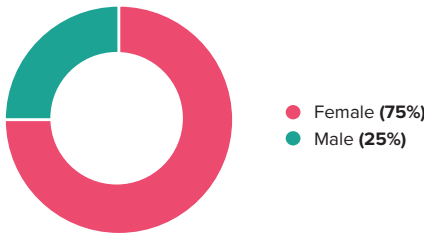
Human resources audit

Given the decentralised nature of our operations and the fact that most staff are on fixed-term contracts ending at different times, our internal auditors recommended a staff audit be conducted. The aim was to establish whether all posts on the payroll were matched by warm bodies out in the field implementing our programmes. The audit was completed in November 2023 and 100% of posts were verified as filled and operational. An information technology audit was performed at the same time. All devices issued were accounted for and the exercise has helped us plan for the replacement of devices that are no longer fit for purpose.

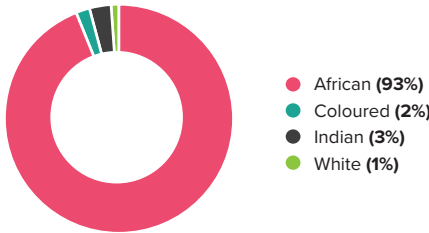
Profile of our human resources

We have a predominantly African and female staff and two-thirds are semi-skilled. CHWCs comprise the single biggest category, followed by various health and social service professionals.

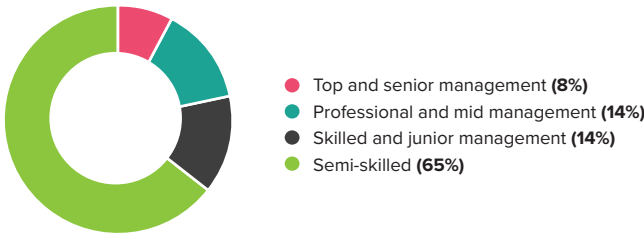
Our staff by gender



Our staff by population group



Our staff by occupational category



Monitoring and Evaluation

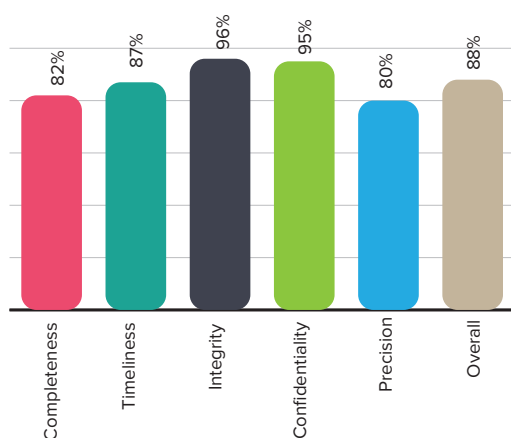
HIGHER HEALTH has a dedicated Monitoring and Evaluation (M&E) Unit which directs and oversees the collection and analysis of data on programme performance at all universities, colleges and mobile clinics. Our M&E framework is based on the three levels of intervention that comprise the HIGHER HEALTH Model.

We have not yet been able to create a fully digitalised system for data collection and storage but this remains a goal for the future and we continue to explore appropriate and affordable options.

Throughout 2023, HIGHER HEALTH's national M&E team undertook meetings with provincial M&E coordinators, visits to PSET institutions, and data quality assessments. Standard operating procedures (SOPs) for data management are in place and manually collected data are audited quarterly.

Data quality assessments conducted at the TVETs and CET colleges in 2023 yielded an overall score of 88%. The scores of 96% and 95% for integrity and confidentiality respectively indicate excellent adherence to the Protection of Personal Information Act and secure management of beneficiaries' information. Completeness and precision of data are aspects that require most attention.

Scores for 2023 data quality assessment at TVET and CET colleges



In addition to mentoring individuals responsible for data collection at provincial and institutional level, we engage with funding organisations that have specific M&E requirements to ensure their standards are met and to resolve quality issues that arise. Two Global Fund principal recipients – AFSA and NACOSA – have rated our data quality positively.

Risk and Compliance

In addition to the staff audit mentioned under Human Resources, HIGHER HEALTH made a concerted effort in 2023/24 to ensure compliance with various laws.

- **Promotion of Access to Information Act:** We compiled a manual to facilitate applications for access to information, as provided in the Act.
- **Protection of Personal Information Act:** We appointed an information officer and deputy information officer who will assume primary responsibility for HIGHER HEALTH's compliance with the Act. Our employees received training on their responsibilities.
- **Public Disclosures Act:** This legislation facilitates the reporting of unethical and fraudulent practices in corporate life by staff members, other stakeholders and members of the public. HIGHER HEALTH conducted training of its staff on whistleblowing procedures and produced materials to create awareness of the right to report unethical behaviour.

Two reports were made by whistleblowers during the financial year. Neither concerned fraud allegations and they were managed by our Human Resources Unit in terms of grievance and disciplinary procedures.

HIGHER HEALTH has always complied with the National Health Act in terms of storing patient records safely and treating patient-related information in the strictest confidence.



SECTION 5

GOVERNANCE

Governance

HIGHER HEALTH is a non-profit company, registered in terms of the Companies Act, and oversight of the organisation is vested in a Board of Directors.

The Board was constituted to ensure representation of stakeholders that had been key to HIGHER HEALTH's development (Universities South Africa [USAf], South African Public Colleges Organisation [SAPCO] and the DHET) and the presence of individuals with specific expertise.

The current chairperson is Prof Wim de Villiers, Vice-Chancellor of Stellenbosch University.

A full list of members appears below.

Members of HIGHER HEALTH Board of Directors

Board member	Designation	Organisation or sub-sector represented or area of expertise
Prof Willem de Villiers (Chairperson)	Vice-Chancellor, Stellenbosch University	Universities/USAf
Prof Marianna Dipiloane Phutsisi (Deputy Chairperson)	Chairperson, SAPCO; Principal, Motheo TVET College	TVET colleges/SAPCO
Dr Precious Phethiwe Matutu	Chief Executive Officer, USAf	Universities/USAf
Ms Sesi Patricia Mahlobogoane	Director of Social Inclusion and Equity, DHET	PSET sector
Mr Xolelo B Phike	Principal, Northlink TVET College	TVET colleges/SAPCO
Prof Thokozile Valerie Mayekiso	Vice-Chancellor, University of Mpumalanga	Universities/USAf
Prof Nancy Refilwe Phaswana-Mafuya	Professor of Epidemiology and Public Health, University of Johannesburg	Public health
Ms Sibongile Mncwabe	Head of Corporate Services, National Student Financial Aid Scheme	PSET sector
Dr Doeke Tromp	Former CFO, Tshwane University of Technology	Financial management and strategic planning
Dr (Prof) Ramneek Ahluwalia <i>Ex officio</i>	CEO, HIGHER HEALTH	

Historically, the Board has had an Audit, Risk, Finance and Investment Committee (ARFIC), and a Human Resources and Remuneration Committee (HRREMC). During the course of this year it decided to split the latter into two committees. Membership of the three committees is as follows:

- Prof Mayekiso, Dr Tromp, Mr Phike, and Mr CM Maimela are members of ARFIC, which has an independent chair, Mr Theo Madurai, CFO of Tshwane University of Technology. Mr Maimela joined the committee during the year as a SAPCO representative.
- Dr Matutu and Prof Phutsisi are members of the HR Committee and the Remuneration Committee.
- Prof Ahluwalia participates in meetings of ARFIC and the Remuneration Committee by invitation only but attends the HR Committee as a member.

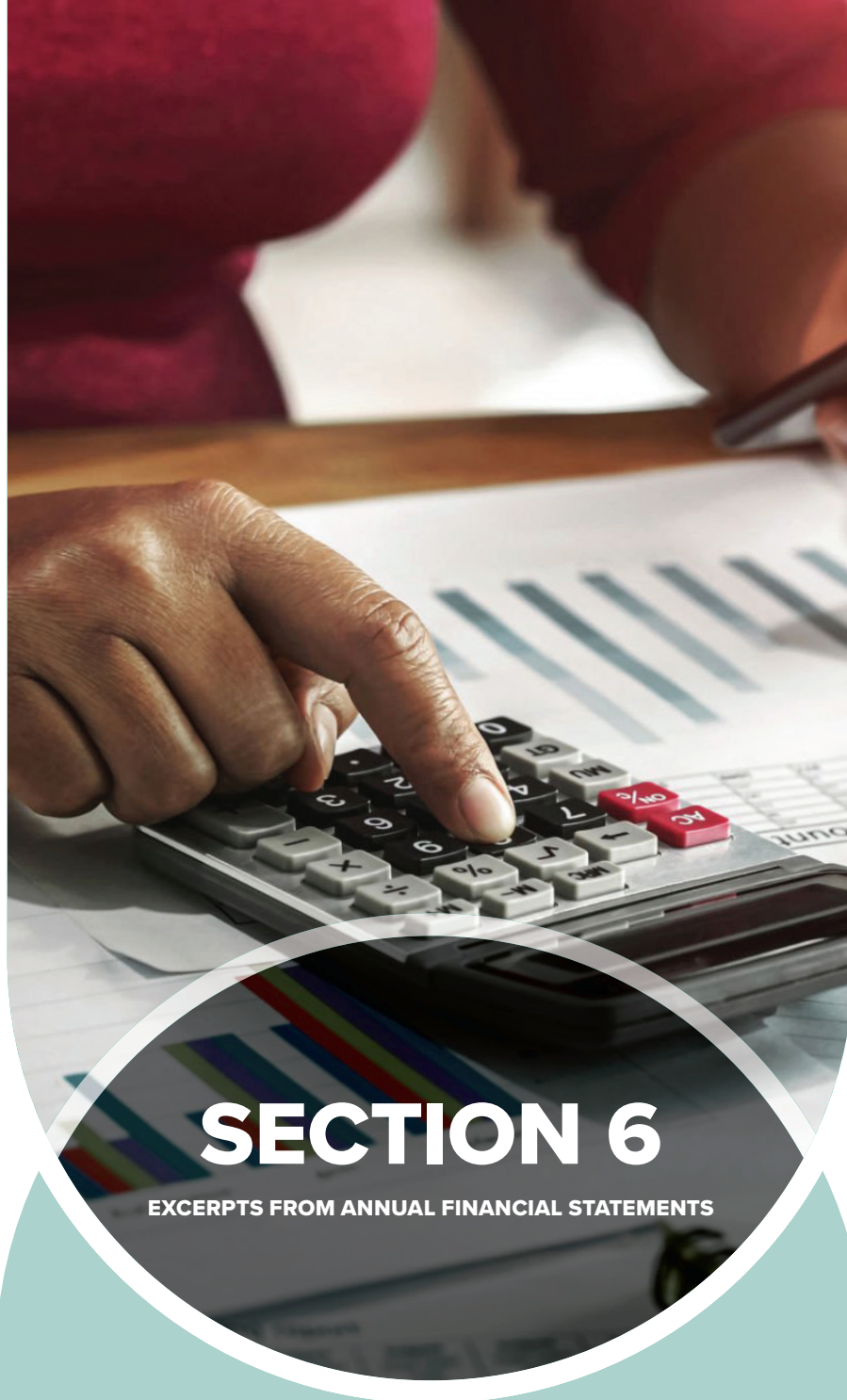
During the year in review, the Board:

- Formally delegated specific contractual authority to the CEO and specific financial authority to the Director: Finance.
- Approved the operational plan for 2024/25 and the budget for that year.
- Approved a range of policies pertaining to the HIGHER HEALTH Academy.
- Amended the organogram to include the position of a Director of E-Learning and Technology, who will guide the further development of the Civic and Health Peer Education Programme.
- Approved the grant allocation totalling R14.3 million to universities.

Governance *continued*

Attendance of members at Board meetings in 2023/24

	May 2023	Aug 2023	Nov 2023	Mar 2024
Prof de Villiers (Chair)	✓	✓	✓	✓
Prof Mayekiso	x	✓	✓	✓
Dr Tromp	✓	✓	✓	✓
Mr Phike	x	✓	x	x
Ms Mahlobogoane	x	✓	✓	✓
Ms Mncwabe	✓	✓	x	✓
Dr Matutu	✓	✓	x	✓
Prof Phutsisi	x	x	x	x
Prof Phaswana-Mafuya	x	x	✓	x
Prof Ahluwalia	✓	✓	✓	✓



SECTION 6

EXCERPTS FROM ANNUAL FINANCIAL STATEMENTS

General Information on Higher Education and Training Health, Wellness and Development Centre

Country of incorporation and domicile	South Africa
Nature of business and principal activities	Health and wellness services and capacity development in higher education institutions, which include universities and TVET colleges
Directors	Prof W De Villiers (Chairperson) Dr (Prof) R Ahluwalia (CEO) Dr D Tromp Prof N Phaswana-Mafuya Prof T Mayekiso Ms Sesi Mahlobogoane Dr P Matutu (Appointed 24 June 2024) Thembisa Futshane (Appointed 24 June 2024) Prof D Phutsisi (Appointed 24 June 2024) Mr XB Phike (Appointed 24 June 2024)
Registered office	262 Rose Avenue Wild Olive Building, Riverfalls Office Park Centurion 0132
Business address	262 Rose Avenue Wild Olive Building, Riverfalls Office Park Centurion 0132
Postal address	262 Rose Avenue Wild Olive Building, Riverfalls Office Park Centurion 0132
Bankers	ABSA Bank Limited and Investec Bank Limited
Auditor	PricewaterhouseCoopers Inc
Company registration number	2017/419731/08
Tax reference number	9864/591/16/0
Level of assurance	These annual financial audited in compliance with the applicable statements have been requirements of the Companies Act of South Africa
Preparer	The annual financial statements were compiled by Afrizen Accounting and Consulting (Pty) Ltd under supervision of Director of Finance Yusuf Khan

Directors' Responsibilities and Approval

The directors are required by the Companies Act 71 of 2008 South Africa to maintain adequate accounting records and are responsible for the content and integrity of the annual financial statements and related financial information included in this report. It is their responsibility to ensure that the annual financial statements satisfy the financial reporting standards with regard to form and content and present fairly the statement of financial position, results of operations and business of the company, and explain the transactions and financial position of the business of the company at the end of the financial year and compliance with the IFRS[®] Accounting Standards.

The annual financial statements are based upon appropriate accounting policies consistently applied throughout the company and supported by reasonable and prudent judgements and estimates.

The directors acknowledge that they are ultimately responsible for the system of internal financial control established by the company and place considerable importance on maintaining a strong control environment. To enable the directors to meet these responsibilities, the Board of Directors sets standards for internal control aimed at reducing the risk of error or loss in a cost-effective manner. The standards include the proper delegation of responsibilities within a clearly defined framework, effective accounting procedures, and adequate segregation of duties to ensure an acceptable level of risk. These controls are monitored throughout the company and all employees are required to maintain the highest ethical standards in ensuring the company's business is conducted in a manner that in all reasonable circumstances is above reproach.

The focus of risk management in the company is on identifying, assessing, managing and monitoring all known forms of risk across the company. While operating risk cannot be fully eliminated, the company endeavours to minimise it by ensuring that appropriate infrastructure, controls, systems and ethical behaviour are applied and managed within predetermined procedures and constraints.

The directors are of the opinion, based on the information and explanations given by management, that the system of internal control provides reasonable assurance that the financial records may be relied on for the preparation of the annual financial statements. However, any system of internal financial control can provide only reasonable, and not absolute, assurance against material misstatement or loss. The going-concern basis has been adopted in preparing the financial statements. Based on forecasts and available cash resources, the directors have no reason to believe that the company will not be a going concern in the foreseeable future. The financial statements support the viability of the company.

The External Auditor is responsible for independently auditing and reporting on the company's financial statements. The financial statements have been examined by the company's External Auditor and their report is presented on pages 8 to 10 (sic).

The annual financial statements and supplementary information, set out on pages 11 to 35 and 36 respectively (sic), including the Directors' Report and Audit, Risk, Finance and Investment Committee Report set out on pages 4 to 5 and 6 to 7 (sic) respectively, which have been prepared on the going-concern basis, were authorised for issue and approved by the Board of Directors on 3 October 2024 and were signed on their behalf by:

Prof W De Villiers
Chairperson

Dr (Prof) R Ahluwalia
Chief Executive Officer

Directors' Report

The directors have pleasure in submitting their report on the annual financial statements of Higher Education and Training Health, Wellness and Development Centre NPC for the year ended 31 March 2024.

1. Incorporation

The company was incorporated on 18 September 2017 and obtained its certificate to commence business on the same day.

2. Nature of business

Higher Education and Training Health, Wellness and Development Centre NPC was incorporated in South Africa with interests in health and wellness services and capacity development in higher education institutions, which include universities and TVET colleges. There were no major changes herein during the year.

The operating results and statement of financial position of the company are fully set out in the attached financial statements and do not in our opinion require any further comment.

3. Directorate

The directors in office at the date of this report are as follows:

Directors	Designation	Nationality
Prof W De Villiers (Chairperson)	Non-executive	South African
Dr D Tromp	Non-executive	South African
Dr (Prof) R Ahluwalia (CEO)	Executive	South African
Prof N Phaswana-Mafuya	Non-executive	South African
Prof T Mayekiso	Non-executive	South African
Ms Sesi Mahlobogoane	Non-executive	South African
Dr P Matutu (Appointed 24/6/24)	Non-executive	South African
Thembisa Futshane (Appointed 24/6/24)	Non-executive	South African
Prof D Phutsisi (Appointed 24/6/24)	Non-executive	South African
Mr XB Phike (Appointed 24/6/24)	Non-executive	South African

4. Directors' interests in contracts

During the financial year, no contracts were entered into which directors or officers of the company had an interest in and which significantly affected the business of the company.

5. Property, plant and equipment

There was no change in the nature of the property, plant and equipment of the company or in the policy regarding their use.

6. Events after reporting date

All events subsequent to the date of the annual financial statements and for which the applicable financial reporting framework requires adjustment or disclosure have been adjusted or disclosed.

7. Going concern

The annual financial statements have been prepared on the basis of accounting policies applicable to a going concern. This basis presumes that funds will be available to finance future operations and that the realisation of assets and settlement of liabilities, contingent obligations and commitments will occur in the ordinary course of business.

The directors believe that the company has adequate financial resources to continue in operation for the foreseeable future and accordingly the annual financial statements have been prepared on a going-concern basis.

The ability of the company to continue as a going concern is dependent on a number of factors. The most significant of these is that the directors continue to procure funding for the ongoing operations of the company where the need arises. Management is comfortable that HIGHER HEALTH will continue to operate.

8. Independent Auditors

PricewaterhouseCoopers Inc continued in office as auditors for the year under review.

9. Secretary

No secretary has been formally appointed during the current financial year.

Audit, Risk, Finance and Investment Committee Report

We are pleased to present our report for the financial year ended 31 March 2024.

The Audit, Risk, Finance and Investment Committee is an independent statutory committee appointed by the directors of the company. The committee has conducted its affairs in compliance with its terms of reference.

1. Members of the committee

The Audit, Risk, Finance and Investment Committee is independent and consists of five independent members. It meets at least twice per year as per its terms of reference.

The Chairman of the Board, Chief Executive Officer, Director of Finance, External Auditor and other assurance providers (legal, compliance, risk, health and safety) attend meetings by invitation only.

The members of the audit committee are:

Name	Appointed	Institution
Mr Theo Madurai (Chairperson)	21/11/2017	Tshwane University of Technology: Chief Financial Officer
Prof TV Mayekiso	21/11/2017	University of Mpumalanga: Vice-Chancellor
Dr Doeke Tromp	21/11/2017	Independent financial consultant
Mr Eminos Manyawi	15/03/2019	Sefako Makgatho Health Sciences University: Chief Financial Officer
Mr Cain M Maimela	14/11/2023	Nkangala TVET College: Principal

2. Meetings held by the committee

The Audit, Risk, Finance and Investment Committee performs the duties laid upon it by section 94(7) of the Companies Act of South Africa by holding meetings with the key role players on a regular basis and by unrestricted access granted to the External Auditor.

3. External auditor

The Audit, Risk, Finance and Investment Committee has satisfied itself that the External Auditor was independent of the company, as set out in section 94(8) of Companies Act 71 of 2008 of South Africa, which includes consideration of previous appointments of the auditor, the extent of other work undertaken by the auditor for the company, and compliance with criteria relating to independence or conflicts of interest as prescribed by the Independent Regulatory Board for Auditors. Requisite assurance was sought and provided by the auditor that internal governance processes within the audit firm support and demonstrate its claim to independence.

The committee ensured that the appointment of the auditor complied with the Companies Act 71 of 2008 South Africa, and any other legislation relating to the appointment of auditors.

The Audit, Risk, Finance and Investment Committee, in consultation with executive management, agreed to the engagement letter, terms, audit plan and budgeted audit fees for the 2024 year.

4. Annual financial statements

The Audit, Risk, Finance and Investment Committee has reviewed the accounting policies and the financial statements of the company and is satisfied that they are appropriate and comply with the IFRS® Accounting Standards, as issued by the International Accounting Standards Board (IASB®).

5. Effectiveness and internal control

The system of internal control applied by the entity over financial reporting and risk management is effective, efficient and transparent. From the audit report on the financial statements and the management report of the external auditor, it was noted that no matters were reported that indicate any material deficiencies in the system of internal control or any deviations therefrom. Accordingly, the committee can report that the system of internal control over financial reporting for the period under review was efficient and effective.

On behalf of the Audit, Risk, Finance and Investment Committee:

Theo Madurai

Chairperson of the Audit, Risk, Finance and Investment Committee

Tuesday 3 October 2024

Independent auditor's report

To the directors of Higher Education Training Health Wellness Development Centre NPC

Our opinion

In our opinion, the financial statements present fairly, in all material respects, the financial position of Higher Education Training Health Wellness Development Centre NPC (the Company) as at 31 March 2024, and its financial performance and cash flows for the year then ended in accordance with IFRS Accounting Standards and the requirements of the Companies Act of South Africa.

What we have audited

Higher Education Training Health Wellness Development Centre NPC's financial statements set out on pages 11 to 35 comprise:

- the statement of financial position as at 31 March 2024;
- the statement of comprehensive income for the year then ended;
- the statement of changes in equity for the year then ended;
- the statement of cash flows for the year then ended; and
- the notes to the financial statements, including material accounting policy information.

Basis for opinion

We conducted our audit in accordance with International Standards on Auditing (ISAs). Our

responsibilities under those standards are further described in the Auditor's responsibilities for the audit of the financial statements section of our report. We believe that the audit evidence we have obtained is sufficient and appropriate to provide a basis for our opinion.

Independence

We are independent of the Company in accordance with the Independent Regulatory Board for Auditors' Code of Professional Conduct for Registered Auditors (IRBA Code) and other independence requirements applicable to performing audits of financial statements in South Africa. We have fulfilled our other ethical responsibilities in accordance with the IRBA Code and in accordance with other ethical requirements applicable to performing audits in South Africa. The IRBA Code is consistent with the corresponding sections of the International Ethics Standards Board for Accountants' International Code of Ethics for Professional Accountants (including International Independence Standards).

Other information

The directors are responsible for the other information. The other information comprises the information included in the document titled "HIGHER EDUCATION TRAINING HEALTH WELLNESS DEVELOPMENT CENTRE NPC Operating as HIGHER HEALTH formerly HEAIDS Annual Financial Statements for the year ended March 31, 2024", which includes the Audit, Risk, Finance and Investment Committee Report and the Directors' Report as required by the Companies Act of South Africa. The other information does not include the financial statements and our auditor's report thereon.

Our opinion on the financial statements does not cover the other information and we do not express an audit opinion or any form of assurance conclusion thereon.

In connection with our audit of the financial statements, our responsibility is to read the other information identified above and, in doing so, consider whether the other information is materially inconsistent with the financial statements or our knowledge obtained in the audit, or otherwise appears to be materially misstated.

If, based on the work we have performed, we conclude that there is a material misstatement of this other information, we are required to report that fact. We have nothing to report in this regard.

Responsibilities of the directors for the financial statements

The directors are responsible for the preparation and fair presentation of the financial statements in accordance with IFRS Accounting Standards and the requirements of the Companies Act of South Africa, and for such internal control as the directors determine is necessary to enable the preparation of financial statements that are free from material misstatement, whether due to fraud or error.

In preparing the financial statements, the directors are responsible for assessing the Company's ability to continue as a going concern, disclosing, as applicable, matters related to going concern and using the going-concern basis of accounting unless the directors either intend to liquidate the Company or to cease operations, or have no realistic alternative but to do so.

Auditor's responsibilities for the audit of the financial statements

Our objectives are to obtain reasonable assurance about whether the financial statements as a whole are free from material misstatement, whether due to fraud or error, and to issue an auditor's report that includes our opinion. Reasonable assurance is a high level of assurance, but is not a guarantee that an audit conducted in accordance with ISAs will always detect a material misstatement when it exists. Misstatements can arise from fraud or error and are considered material if, individually or in the aggregate, they could reasonably be expected to influence the economic decisions of users taken on the basis of these financial statements.

As part of an audit in accordance with ISAs, we exercise professional judgement and maintain professional scepticism throughout the audit. We also:

- Identify and assess the risks of material misstatement of the financial statements, whether due to fraud or error, design and perform audit procedures responsive to those risks, and obtain audit evidence that is sufficient and appropriate to provide a basis for our opinion. The risk of not detecting a material misstatement resulting from fraud is higher than for one resulting from error, as fraud may involve collusion, forgery, intentional omissions, misrepresentations, or the override of internal control.
- Obtain an understanding of internal control relevant to the audit in order to design audit procedures that are appropriate in the circumstances, but not for the purpose of expressing an opinion on the effectiveness of the Company's internal control.
- Evaluate the appropriateness of accounting policies used and the reasonableness of accounting estimates and related disclosures made by the directors.
- Conclude on the appropriateness of the directors' use of the going-concern basis of accounting and, based on the audit evidence obtained, whether a material uncertainty exists related to events or conditions that may cast significant doubt on the Company's ability to continue as a going concern. If we conclude that a material uncertainty exists, we are required to draw attention in our auditor's report to the related disclosures in the financial statements or, if such disclosures are inadequate, to modify our opinion. Our conclusions are based on the audit evidence obtained up to the date of our auditor's report. However, future events or conditions may cause the Company to cease to continue as a going concern.
- Evaluate the overall presentation, structure and content of the financial statements, including the disclosures, and whether the financial statements represent the underlying transactions and events in a manner that achieves fair presentation.

We communicate with the directors regarding, among other matters, the planned scope and timing of the audit and significant audit findings, including any significant deficiencies in internal control that we identify during our audit.

PricewaterhouseCoopers Inc.

PricewaterhouseCoopers Inc

Director: R Ramdhany

Registered Auditor

Johannesburg, South Africa

3 October 2024

Statement of Financial Position

as at 31 March 2024

	2024 R	2023 Restated* R	2022 Restated* R
ASSETS			
Non-current assets			
Property, plant and equipment	8 181 821	7 590 884	9 523 923
Right-of-use assets	6 157 946	714 404	–
	14 339 767	8 305 288	9 523 923
Current assets			
Inventories	488 082	3 659 878	4 396 741
Trade and other receivables	7 870 871	12 827 712	3 116 441
Investments	19 271 663	17 740 155	16 657 908
Cash and cash equivalents	12 172 414	21 050 616	39 004 506
	39 803 030	55 278 361	63 175 596
Total assets	54 142 797	63 583 649	72 699 519
EQUITY AND LIABILITIES			
Equity			
Retained income	29 599 789	26 526 089	29 029 678
Liabilities			
Non-current liabilities			
Lease liabilities	5 509 024	247 778	529 722
Current liabilities			
Trade and other payables	3 945 586	5 936 177	3 127 840
Finance lease liabilities	1 622 619	1 032 513	2 366 736
Deferred income	11 180 811	27 859 206	36 148 252
Provisions	2 260 279	1 981 886	1 497 291
Bank credit facility	24 689	–	–
	19 033 984	36 809 782	43 140 119
Total liabilities	24 543 008	37 057 560	43 669 841
Total equity and liabilities	54 142 797	63 583 649	72 699 519

* Refer to note 21 (reproduced for convenient reference on page 58 of this annual report) for the restatement of the prior period error.

Statement of Profit or Loss and Other Comprehensive Income

for the year ended 31 March 2024

	2024 R	2023 Restated* R
Revenue	109 005 130	93 322 641
Other operating income	3 026 106	897 385
Other operating gains (losses)	(160 819)	(3 742)
Operating expenses	(109 624 967)	(97 629 731)
Operating surplus (loss)	2 245 450	(3 413 447)
Finance cost paid	(703 268)	(172 389)
Fair value gains (losses)	1 531 508	1 082 247
Surplus (deficit) for the year	3 073 690	(2 503 589)
Other comprehensive income	–	–
Total comprehensive income (loss) for year	3 073 690	(2 503 589)

HIGHER HEALTH is an approved public benefit organisation in terms of section 30 of the Income Tax Act 58 of 1962 and the receipts and accruals of HIGHER HEALTH are exempt from income tax in terms of section 10(1)(cN) of the Act.

* Refer to note 21 (reproduced for convenient reference on page 58 of this annual report) for the restatement of the prior period error.

Statement of Changes in Equity

for the year ended 31 March 2024

	Retained income R	Total equity R
Opening balance as previously reported: 1Apr 2022	9 651 578	9 651 578
Prior period error (Refer note 21)	19 378 100	19 378 100
Restated balance at 1 April 2022	29 029 678	29 029 678
Total comprehensive loss for 2023 restated	(2 503 589)	(2 503 589)
Restated balance at 1 April 2023	26 526 099	26 526 099
Total comprehensive income for 2024	3 073 690	3 073 690
Balance at 31 March 2024	29 599 789	29 599 789

Statement of Cash Flows

for the year ended 31 March 2024

	2024 R	2023 Restated* R
Cash flows utilised in operating activities		
Cash used in operations	(4 614 212)	(12 788 204)
Finance cost paid	(703 268)	(172 389)
Cash from operating activities: credit card facility	24 689	–
Net cash utilised in operating activities	(5 292 791)	(12 960 593)
Cash flows utilised in investing activities		
Purchase of property, plant and equipment	(1 682 154)	(2 612 239)
Proceeds from sale of property, plant and equipment	–	207 370
Net cash from investing activities	(1 682 154)	(2 404 869)
Cash flows utilised in financing activities		
Cash repayments on lease liabilities	(1 903 257)	(2 588 428)
Total cash movement for the year	(8 878 202)	(17 953 890)
Cash and cash equivalents at beginning of year	21 050 616	39 004 506
Cash and cash equivalents at end of year	12 172 414	21 050 616

* Refer to note 21 (reproduced for convenient reference on page 58 of this annual report) for the restatement of the prior period error.

Notes to the annual financial statements

for the year ended 31 March 2024

21. Prior period errors

21.1 Reclassification of the Investec investment

This relates to the reclassification of the Investec investment from cash and cash equivalents to Investments. The Investec investment has been corrected to be recognised and disclosed within investments as it does not meet the definition of cash and cash equivalents.

The correction of prior period errors resulted in adjustments as follows:

	2023	2022
Cash and cash equivalents		
Previously report	38 790 771	55 662 414
Reclassification to investments	(17 740 155)	(16 657 908)
	21 050 616	39 004 506
Investments		
Previously reported	–	–
Reclassification from cash and cash equivalents	17 740 155	16 657 908
	17 740 155	16 657 908

21.2 Correction of:

Current liabilities: deferred Income and retained Income: An unconditional grant was received from DHET. Revenue was previously not recognised on receipt of the unconditional grant. The error has been corrected to recognise the revenue from the unconditional grant. There was no impact on the revenue recognised in the 2023 financial year as the error related to amounts that should have been recognised prior to 2023.

Surplus/(deficit): The fair value gain on the Investec investment was credited to deferred income instead of the fair value gain account. The error has been corrected to recognise the fair value gain on investment within surplus/(deficit) instead of against the deferred income. The impact of the above correction of errors is indicated below.

	2023	2022
Current liabilities: deferred income		
Previously reported	48 319 553	55 526 352
Recognition of revenue from unconditional grants	(20 460 347)	(19 378 100)
	27 859 206	36 148 252
Retained income	2023	2022
Previously reported	6 065 743	9 651 578
Recognition of revenue from unconditional grants	19 378 100	19 378 100
Fair value gain on investment	1 082 256	–
	26 526 099	29 029 678

21.3 Correction of errors: cashflow statement

Cash flows from investing activities and cash flows from financing activities: The non-cash additions arising from the recognition of the right of use assets was previously accounted for within the cash flows from investing and financing activities. The cashflow statement has been corrected to account for the non-cash transactions. The impact of the above correction of errors is indicated below.

	2023
Cash flows from investing activities	
Property, plant and equipment as reported previously	(3 584 500)
Adjustment from non-cash additions from right-of-use assets	972 261
	(2 612 239)
Cash flows from financing activities	2023
Cash repayments on lease liabilities as reported previously	(1 616 167)
Adjustment for non-cash additions arising from right-of-use assets	(972 261)
	(2 588 428)



HIGHER HEALTH

Higher Education & Training: Health, Wellness and Development Centre

Wild Olive Building, 262 Rose Avenue,
Riverfalls Office Park, Centurion, Pretoria
+27 (0)12 030 0113
info@higherhealth.ac.za

www.higherhealth.ac.za